straying from the thunder

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/33794572.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra)

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by enigmaticEditor

Summary

Desperate and backed into a corner, Catra claims the Black Garnet for her own. This predictably blows up in her face, and now she has to pick up the pieces.

But maybe she won’t have to do it alone.

Notes

It finally happened. I finally titled a fic with a song lyric. I suppose some things just can't be avoided. I even had a working title for this that would have been just fine, but then that song got stuck in my head for days, something about it nagging at me... and at long last it clicked. Oh well. At least it works pretty damn well.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Another narrow dodge. She'd felt the heat of the laser closing in on her, only just dissipating before it made contact. Blocking out Hordak's crazed ranting, she bounded up and into the shadows of the Black Garnet chamber.

Catra was fully aware of the limits of Hordak's new combat enhancements. The radius and duration of the bursts could be controlled, and during the invasion of Salineas he had displayed mathematical precision in using only the energy necessary for the task. If he hadn't, it would have eventually overheated and shut down well before the battle had concluded.

Hordak was showing no such restraint now. She could already hear the whirring of the device on his arm growing louder. If she could just survive a few more minutes, he'd be defenseless, and she would take great pleasure in ripping the power source out of his chest and destroying it before she allowed him to die.

It was a calming thought, and it nearly proved disastrous. Her claws unsheathed, itching to tear into the mechanical oversuit Hordak was so fond of, and the sound of them scraping against the piping gave away her position.

A pinprick of red below followed by a roar of burning light severed the beam she was balancing on, sending her tumbling to the floor of the chamber. She landed hard, but on her feet, and rolled with the momentum. Hordak's next blast fired at the spot she'd just vacated, and as he followed her, Catra gritted her teeth and dodged up and behind the Garnet itself.

She hadn't wanted to get near the damn thing. It smelled of magic, of burning ozone, and even of *her* after so many years. As it had when she'd touched it as a kitten, the runestone shocked

her, but she withstood it. She was stronger now. This pain was nothing.

She didn't expect Hordak to simply take aim at the Garnet itself and fire.

The noise it made was... almost alive. The Black Garnet *screamed* at the impact. Electricity flooded the air, throwing her and Hordak back to opposite sides of the chamber.

Every sense whited out. She couldn't hear, see, even smell. For a span of time she could not measure, she laid there, twitching, some small conscious partition of her mind expecting to die any second and another, weaker part of her trembling at the burst of magic that had been so alike that of the former keeper of the Garnet.

And yet, the buzzing slowly faded, and Catra clawed her way back to her feet. As her vision cleared, she spotted her opponent lying among rubble, not having regained control of his augmented body.

Perfect.

She strode over to him, voice cracked at first but gaining strength every second. "Well, Hordak, it's been fun, but it looks like your part in this story ends here. Tell Entrapta I said hello."

A part of her recoiled at her own words, but she shoved it down, kneeling next to Hordak's immobile form, unsheathing her claws once more.

Suddenly, she heard a noise she knew very well. The telltale chiming of the Queen of Brightmoon's arrival. She sprung upright, turning her head to find-

Scorpia.

Scorpia was here, looking between her and Hordak with alarm.

With the Queen at her side.

They were here for *her*.

Catra didn't think there was much more of her sanity she could lose, but something in her mind snapped upon realizing that Scorpia, too, had not only turned against her, but was ready to fight her. To kill her. Just like Adora. Just like Shadow Weaver. Just like Hordak.

Every single person in her life betrayed her. Why should she have expected any different?

No matter. She'd rise above. She'd show them all.

Baring her fangs, Catra snarled. "Oh, hello, Sparkles. Scorpia. Come to watch me finish off my old boss? By all means, enjoy the show. It'll be your turn next."

Recovering from the shock, the Queen raised her fists as they started to glow. Scorpia only stared at Catra, her usually open expression unreadable.

For a long moment no one made a move, the roaring of Catra's heartbeat in her ears and her ragged breathing the only sounds she heard.

The traitor spoke first. "Wildcat, I..."

In an instant, something in her eyes shifted, and she leapt forward directly at Catra.

Scorpia moved faster than she could have believed. Catra started to dodge, only for a wave of heat to buffet her. Her gaze snapped to the side.

Hordak had her. Point blank. The weapon was about to fire.

In the fraction of a second Catra had left, she relaxed. It was over. Cut to ribbons or obliterated in an instant, it didn't matter. If

Scorpia didn’t kill her, Hordak would. She’d welcome it.

She didn’t expect Scorpia to shove her out of the way.

When everything stopped spinning and Catra scrambled to her feet, feeling the sting of new scrapes and bruises as she rose, the Queen's voice pierced through the ringing in her ears.

“You’ve ruined everything,” Glimmer screamed. “You couldn’t just... you couldn’t just die when you were supposed to. And now you’ve doomed us all again. Without Scorpia-” She cut off, her fury having gone beyond the point of mere words.

Catra said nothing. She was staring at the broken form of her old friend, crumpled in a heap of scorched carapace.

She wanted to imagine that she saw the rise and fall of Scorpia’s chest. One pincer was a charred ruin, but there wasn’t any obviously fatal damage. She would be okay, right? She was *Scorpia*. She couldn’t go down.

Catra shook herself. Why did she care? So what, the traitor had switched sides again for a moment. Sparkles’s loss, her gain. She had another chance to come out on top. Hordak was out of commission once more. Resilient as he was, he'd awaken in mere minutes, but that was enough.

She lunged at the Queen, the Black Garnet still spitting sparks behind her.

The battle hadn’t lasted long. Catra was already exhausted, and the rage of the Queen of Brightmoon was not to be denied. The tactician in her had foreseen as much. In less than a minute, Catra was pinned underneath the wreckage of the chamber walls. Not far from where Scorpia lay, still unmoving. Glimmer had stood over her, and in her moment of hesitation, only just discorporated in time to avoid a sneak attack from Hordak.

She’d answered his challenge, and their duel had led them away from the chamber. Catra wasn’t even important enough to kill.

Far, far worse had been the reappearance of Double Trouble. For a moment, Catra had dared to hope that they would help her, as they had back in the cavern months ago. Instead, they tore- surely not her heart, that was long gone- *something* out of her with their taunts and left her to her fate.

It was over.

She tried to chuckle. It came out as a cough. An ancient superweapon? Please. She'd all but emptied the Fright Zone for that last assault. If the princesses had truly been in disarray- they were quite volatile for military assets- it would have been enough. All of them working together, with Adora... She-Ra... at the helm? By the end of the day, the majority of her forces would be captured, incapacitated, or dead.

For the briefest of moments, Catra found that the idea of the latter upset her. Her claws twitched, aching to sink into her own skin. She was still so *weak.*

Her army wouldn't retreat. She'd made sure that they feared *her* far more than any of the princesses. No, if they fled, it wouldn't be back to the Horde.

The weapon would be unleashed upon a ghost town. Her, the damned spirit within.

Catra lay there, listening to the faraway sounds of battle. Hordak's bellows, Glimmer's shrieks, the shearing and shuddering of metal. It gave her the smallest bit of satisfaction that Sparkles was having trouble putting her old boss down. She didn't know him like Catra did, and Adora's littlest sidekick wasn't that clever a fighter.

That was what happened when you were born with power. You relied on it. Used it as a crutch. It made you soft. Pathetic. Hers was true strength; mind and body honed to the sharpest and

deadliest of blades, capable of going blow for blow with the likes of She-Ra. Everyone had weaknesses, and she was as much an expert at finding them in others as she was at ridding herself of each and every one.

And yet... Queen Glimmer had bested her twice. The gap between them was too large for Catra to overcome. In a way, that was her fault; Double Trouble had informed her months ago of the reason for Sparkles shedding her old limitations. With the former Queen lost, an unintended but originally not unwelcome consequence of Catra's own machinations, the full power of Brightmoon's runestone had shifted to her daughter. Sparkles was almost on par with She-Ra herself.

There was no way for Catra to win. No plan she could put together. The last of the adrenaline of combat had faded. The rubble pinning her restricted her breathing. In all likelihood, she would pass out soon, and either die in her sleep in some unknown cataclysm or wake up as the Rebellion's prisoner. As Adora's prisoner. And finally, she'd have lost for good.

She hadn't noticed closing her eyes, but she opened them. It took a moment for her vision to clear.

No.

There was one way out.

One way she could become strong enough.

One way she could still hurt Adora.

One way she could take out the Queen.

Shadow Weaver had done it. And she was *better* than Shadow Weaver.

It was agonizing, but Catra forced aching muscles into action. Digging her claws into the floor for purchase, she tensed.

Gathered what strength she had left. Thought of Adora, victorious and *smug*.

She yanked herself out from under the heap of metal and concrete, it collapsing to fill the gap she'd left. Catra paid it no mind as she crawled forward, and spared only a glance for Scorpia, who still lay where she had fallen.

The Black Garnet.

Instrument of her torture.

And now, instrument of her salvation.

She could sink no lower. This was the final insult, the ultimate debasement of herself.

Growling, she stood.

No. It was power. A way for her to win. As she always had, she would use every tool at her disposal. Her history with this hunk of crystal was irrelevant.

Catra placed her hand upon it.

“Mine.”

It shocked her. If she'd had the energy, she'd have rolled her eyes.

“Mine,” she repeated, claws scraping the Garnet. They left no mark upon its surface.

She braced herself for another shock, but it didn't come. A strange sensation passed through her, sending prickles down Catra's spine. It was almost like something within the runestone was... listening.

“You are *mine*, do you hear me?” She tore each word out of that empty place in her chest. “You owe me. You hurt me. You served

her. I defeated her. Here. Did you see that? Were you watching?”

She was talking to a stone. Maybe she really had snapped. And yet, the Garnet was glowing. The smell of ozone filled the ruined chamber.

“I am Catra. Commander of the Horde. Nemesis of She-Ra. Conqueror of Etheria. And you. Are. *Mine*.”

The Black Garnet burst to life.

Shadows like storm clouds swirled around her, lifting her off her feet and into the air. Catra didn't struggle. She didn't say anything, even as the crackling grew louder. A bolt of electricity burned through her, then another, and another, until it found a home within her, in that void where her heart must have once been. The power hummed under her skin.

At least, she thought bitterly, all-too-familiar red lightning arcing around her form, this magic rock couldn’t betray her.

Hordak must have gotten his temper under control. And, for that matter, Sparkles must be throwing one hell of a tantrum, unable to do the simple work of identifying her opponent's weak point. Their battle dragged on inside the empty factory, magic failing to overcome technology and vice versa. Before she even reached them, Catra could hear their ragged, heavy breathing.

Tipping the scales was all too easy.

The already flickering lights shorted out. Shadows poured into the room, cloaking her. From the darkness, from Catra's unsheathed claws, came a burst of pale red destruction. She bent it around her wrist, then swung it forward, as if she were wielding her whip. The bolt of power extended, following her will with precision, striking her target dead on.

Hordak fell, the buzzing of the scorched air drowning out his cry of pain and shock. Sparks flew from his metal chassis, augmented limbs twitching uncontrollably. Another, more carefully aimed stroke of lightning tore his power source from his chest, sending it flying out of sight.

The Queen of Brightmoon stumbled backwards. To her credit, she regained her footing, leaning on her staff, and peered warily in the direction from which the attack had come.

"...Scorpia?"

Catra stepped out of the shadows.

"No."

Glimmer went wide-eyed, raised a hand to her mouth... and started to *laugh*.

It was so unexpected, Catra just stared, all her rage forgotten. Her summoned shadows dissipated, returning to the dark corners whence they came. "What."

"I..." Sparkles wheezed, shoulders shaking. "I should be *thanking* you. I..." Another burst of giggles came from her, which Catra answered with a growl. "I wanted the Garnet activated. I mean, I'd have rather Scorpia got it, but..." Her speech devolved into laughter once more.

Anger swooped back in, and with it rose unbidden lightning, scorching the ground at her feet. "*What*, Sparkles."

"Long story short? Thanks for the power boost, Horde scum. With all the runestones up and running, we're *unstoppable*. It doesn't matter that Adora..." Her expression changed, all traces of levity gone. "Never mind. You're finished, Catra. Your army is being wiped out as we speak. Garnet or no Garnet, you're alone. I'm perfectly happy to give you all the personal attention that you deserve, and I'm going to enjoy every second of it."

The Queen drew herself up, leveling her staff in Catra's direction. “Surrender.”

Ignoring the bottomless pit that had opened up within her once more, Catra bared her teeth. “Never.”

“I'd hoped you'd say that.”

Glimmer took one step forward, her radiance suddenly blinding as harsh pink light filled the room. In response, Catra let her power surge, sparking and hissing against her foe's aura. Lightning rested in her palms, curled around her wrists and up her arms, begging to be set free.

Catra lunged-

-and stumbled, collapsing to her knees barely a meter from where Glimmer, too, was falling to the ground. Puppets with their marionette strings cut, the both of them.

Pain was a friend of Catra's. Indeed, physical pain had long been her salve; it was far easier to handle than the storm raging within her head. How many times had she made that trade, a scrape of her claws against her skin, a few drops of blood wetting her fur, for a moment's blessed release as her body rushed to soothe itself? It never lasted, but it was enough to keep her sane. Keep her focused. Pain was a tool, just like any other.

This... this was something else.

She was being drained. Her body, her mind, her soul. Bit by bit, torn away from her, bleeding from wounds inside and out. Through unfocused eyes, she watched listlessly as patterns etched their way onto her skin, glowing ominously under her fur. Agony followed them, her body twisting and her tail thrashing wildly. An attempt to draw forth the Garnet's energy was rewarded by every sensation worsening.

She couldn't believe it.

The fucking magic rock betrayed her.

“No...” came the breathless gasp of her would-be opponent. And then: “Adora was right.”

Possibly no other words could have given Catra the strength to break through the pain and lift her head.

Her fury stuttered and died after her first glance; Glimmer looked as bad as Catra felt. The same marks upon her skin, her energy pouring out of her into the sky through the shattered ceiling. A quick glance confirmed the same multicolored stream rose above Catra's own head.

In between wails, Catra heard, “Light Hope... betrayed... used me... activated the Heart... have to... have to stop...”

How odd it was, she reflected dimly through the pain, to be on the other side of this. “Welcome to... my life, Sparkles,” she managed.

This was ignored. “Have to stop...” Abruptly, Glimmer focused on her, meeting Catra's eyes. “Help me.”

Catra stared.

“Everyone... everyone is going to die. The weapon... I can't control it. It will... it will... everyone... you, me, Adora...”

“...How?”

“W- what?”

“How do we stop it?”

If Glimmer had asked why she was agreeing to help, Catra couldn't have answered her. But that didn't happen. “It needs... all the runestones... all of... us.” Another broken cry escaped her. “Help me... get to the Garnet.” She turned her staff upright, bracing for an attempt to stand. “Destroy... destroy it.”

“I... I don't think you can, Sparkles. Hordak... he hit it. With that fucking laser of his. Didn't- didn't leave a mark.”

“I have... to try.” Glimmer hauled herself up.

Catra followed suit, limbs shaking. She reached forward and grabbed Glimmer's shoulder. “Wait. Wait. There's... there's another way. You said it... it needs us?”

“Yes?”

“If we're not... here anymore...”

Understanding dawned in pale pink eyes. Then, resignation. The Queen of Brightmoon nodded at her, taking a shaky step back and letting Catra's outstretched hand fall to her side.

“Kill me.”

Minutes ago, Catra would have been more than willing. But now...

Sparkles had been manipulated. Betrayed. And by the sound of it, abandoned by Adora. Catra may as well have been looking into a mirror, except that she actually felt sorry for the woman standing before her. It was a disgusting feeling, and yet, she bent to it, hating herself all the more for how weak she had once more proved herself to be.

“No.”

“Dammit, Catra!” The words carried a hint of crazed, empty amusement. “For once in your *life,* can't you-”

And then the whole world shifted.

The ruined walls blazed with light, a wall of blinding nothingness enveloping the sky outside. It looked familiar.

Portal. Catra couldn't help but clutch her right arm. Glimmer screamed and struck the ground with her staff, as if that would

somehow stop the inevitable.

The nothing vanished as quickly as it had come. In its place were... sparkling pinpricks, scattered like sand across the sky.

This calamity was only the beginning. Whatever power had broken the sky was still draining them, and Catra met Glimmer's eyes again. Understanding without words passed between them.

Catra didn't think it was necessary to say out loud. Glimmer, evidently, thought otherwise. “This is our fault.”

“Yeah.”

“Come with me. To... to the Garnet. We can still... you can give the powers back... we have to try *something.*”

“Fine.”

Glimmer extended a hand, and Catra took it. Together, they hobbled a few shaky steps... and then collapsed, groaning. It was too much. The agony built, faster and faster, rising to an unbearable conclusion. Black played at the edges of Catra's vision, and she lacked the strength to fight it any longer. Looking up at the strange new sky, she laid back and... thought of Adora.

The pain vanished.

She blinked. And sat up.

At her side, Glimmer was doing the same.

“What just happened-” Catra started. It was cut off by an involuntary hiss, every instinct in her body screaming *danger,* her fur flaring up in alarm. Something was wrong. She had to get away. Now.

Dimly, she heard the voice of Adora's other lackey calling out to Sparkles from somewhere nearby and receiving a frantic response. Glimmer rose unsteadily but swiftly to her feet and ran

towards her friend. Catra twisted herself onto all fours and scrambled away in the opposite direction as the air around them began to glow green.

She almost made it, diving behind a pile of rubble, but something grabbed hold of her, locking her in place.

And everything went white.

Chapter End Notes

> This is, in my opinion, inherently inferior to how it went down in canon. I didn’t think so at the time Season 4 dropped, but Season 5 proved me dead wrong. Not to say this doesn’t work pretty damn well too, but I know when I’m beaten. So this isn’t me dunking on canon or anything. I simply thought the idea would be fun to explore. As such, I'll be sticking pretty close to the aesthetic of canon, aside from the occasional worldbuilding tangent. Because that's something I literally cannot stop myself from doing, ever, in any context.
>
> I will not be covering Season 5 step by step, for two reasons. First, I'm locking myself into Catra's perspective. Second, a lot of events would not substantially change, and thus insisting on covering them anyway would be a Mortal Fanfic Sin. As such, this is not going to be a particularly long fic. Or rather, it isn't. All but the epilogue is already done, and I'm looking at a total of a little over 20k words. Plan is to post a chapter every three days or so.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Why?”

“Why what?”

“Why did you tell him that I was needed to power the Heart? And only me?” Glimmer kept her voice low.

“Because I don't want him to know. Obviously.”

Two weeks they'd been here, and Glimmer hadn't said a word about the events immediately preceding their arrival on the Velvet Glove, with one exception. She'd asked if Scorpia was alive, to which Catra had responded in the affirmative. She'd checked before she left the Garnet chamber, and had despised herself for it.

The reason for the delay was simple, and Catra found it almost a relief that it hadn't needed to be said. Adora would have- she cut off that line of thought. Point is, when she wasn't yelling, Catra could see the traces of a woman raised to be royalty. To navigate the chaos that was leadership. They'd both had the sense to keep their mouths shut on certain topics, even when they appeared to be alone, until they had ascertained that Prime's mantra was only that and not a statement of fact.

“And why is that... Catra?”

Being addressed by name for the first time since they'd arrived almost made Catra turn around, but she didn't. Back-to-back was the only way they could talk. In a very real sense, this was the woman who had stolen Adora from her. And her, the one who had, indirectly or not, cost Glimmer her mother. They had no business being civil with each other, and they both knew it.

But there was no one else, and so Catra huddled against the force field, pretending she could feel the warmth of contact and hating the idea in the same breath.

At any rate, Catra didn't feel like acknowledging that question. Glimmer knew why, she was just still obsessed with getting Catra to say something else. Insisting there was more to her than the will to power, the instinct to survive, the desire to harm.

The subject changed, by her hand. "How'd you figure out Prime was full of shit?"

"Prime sees all, knows all," quoted Glimmer. "If that was true, he wouldn't *say* it. If he didn't enjoy the game of dragging information out of us, he wouldn't bother with all this. It's obvious. Or it was by the end of the tour of his stupid treasure room. You?"

"Same. Shadow Weaver was just like him." *And I'm just like her. Even more, now.*

Her ears picked up the subtle, muffled sounds of Sparkles shifting in place.

"She'll be held accountable, you know. For everything. I was just... using her."

Ha. "No, she was using you. And I don't want to fucking talk about her with you, *princess*."

"Okay... princess."

Catra didn't come by again for four days.

"You know what the worst part is?"

Catra didn't bother prompting her. Glimmer would continue regardless of her acknowledgment. In that, she reminded Catra

of- no. No one. No one she cared about.

“I'm bored. I'm being held prisoner by a galactic tyrant, and I'm *bored.* This has been the longest three weeks of my life, and that includes when my aunt- uh, that's my father's sister- made a 'surprise' extended visit to Brightmoon when I was fourteen.”

“I know what an aunt is.”

“Oh.” A pause. “Adora didn't.”

She *detested* the way every muscle in her body tensed just from hearing the name. Even after Prime pointed it out and used it against her, she just couldn't stop. “Adora didn't know a lot of things.”

Having learned well what would make Catra get up and walk away, Glimmer didn't push. “I'd kill for a book. Any book,” she continued.

“Don't envy you, Sparkles. Sure, I used to get thrown in solitary for a bit if I really pissed off Shadow Weaver, but I think the record was ten days.” Catra let herself grin. “And then I threw *her* in the same cell for a couple months.”

Why it had ended after that span of time was something she decided not to think about.

“What about you?” Catra made a questioning grunt, and Glimmer clarified. “What's the worst part of being here for you?”

Fuck off, was the first response that came to mind, but something else came out of Catra's mouth instead. “I can still *feel* it.” She didn't need to say what. Or she wouldn't. “Can't do anything with it, not even a spark, but I know it's there. It's in my head, in my...”

Her voice trailed off before she could say *soul.* “I'm magic now. Maybe forever. And that's fucking stupid.”

A laugh wasn't the response she expected.

“What?”

“Catra, you... do you not... okay.” Glimmer cleared her throat, and when she spoke again, her tone had changed to something unidentifiable. “Have you ever met another... er. Anyone else like you? With the fur, ears, tail? All that?”

“Couple of times. Never bothered to stop for a chat, I was kind of busy running an army. Why?”

“So you don't know what you're called.”

Catra stared at the blank white wall across from her. She knew she was *something.* A particular type of the countless animal-like people that, more often than not, had an actual animal counterpart. Hell, Rogelio had once been almost indistinguishable from the lizards she would scamper around the Fright Zone in pursuit of. She could always tell the difference by scent, but she'd sometimes pretended otherwise to spook Kyle.

She'd been called a “kitten” when she was small. Shadow Weaver had used the term a handful of times. Usually paired with a word like “insolent” or “useless.” Double Trouble had called her “kitten” as well, but they were using it to mock her, she was sure. Scorpia had called her “kitty” once, before swapping to... that other nickname. Was it one of those, or something similar?

Too late. Sparkles had taken her silence to mean that she didn't know. “You're a *magicat.*”

“...So?”

She registered the now-familiar sound of Glimmer sighing in exasperation, though it was still laced with... something else. “Magicat,” she repeated, slower this time. “Magic is in your *name.* I've seen your claws cut through steel. She-Ra has smacked you into a cliff hard enough to shatter the rock and you get back up. Did you never think that was odd?”

Catra didn't respond. Suddenly, the air in the corridor seemed thin, and she kept trying to look at her hands only to flinch away. It's not like she *hadn't* noticed that her claws always seemed to be only as sharp and strong as she needed at the moment, but... it just... it was a part of her. As natural as her ears or tail, or that one noise she used to make around Adora sometimes that the other girl could never imitate despite not insignificant effort. Why would she question it?

When she felt like she could breathe again, she asked, “What are... magicats... supposed to be able to do?”

A quick motion from behind her. Probably a shrug. “Nothing too special, before you start thinking you can *actually* beat Adora. The claws are the only really magical thing. Like how my- like how Fl- like how... most of the people of Elberon can fly with their wings even though they should be way too heavy. And... weren't you the one putting lizardfolk on the front lines so much because they regenerate? Anyway, other than that it's just. Physical stuff. You know what you can do better than me.”

“Oh.”

“It feels so *weird* to have to tell you this. Even Shadow Weaver should have... I mean, she let you have that mask.”

“My... mask?” She reached up to feel the familiar edges of it.

“It's a magicat warrior mask. From before their kingdom fell.”

“Why do you *know* that?”

It had been almost an accusatory shout, frustration and anger refusing to be quelled, but the answer was given calmly. Carefully, even. “I was raised as a princess. I had lessons. I'm supposed to know these things. But I guess no one ever bothered to...”

And then Catra realized what was lurking behind those words.

Pity.

She left, ignoring Sparkles calling out after her.

Prime sees all, knows all.

Its meaning had been revealed to her. It was an unassailable truth. For Prime, his reign eternal, the past, present, and future were, are, and shall be one. Through his own eyes and those of his brothers, Prime shall perceive the totality of the universe. Only organic senses would do; to directly integrate or add to his vast knowledge and wisdom with technology would make him impure. Capable of corruption. Lesser than the luminous being he was.

She was a mere drop in the vast ocean of Prime's consciousness, and she knew: there was no hiding from Prime, nor was it right that any should seek to.

Her subterfuge had amused him. Against any opponent save Prime, perhaps her gambit would have even been successful. She would have been struck down for her insolence, and upon her death, she would have found victory in the deactivation of the weapon threatening her homeworld. But Prime was practical, and thus unwilling to discard any tool until he knew its full capabilities.

And how capable was she!

Prime had rarely ever allowed individual warriors to lead his armies into battle, but an exception was being made for her. After all, she commanded a power the likes of which Prime had not seen in many an age. One of near limitless destruction, and more importantly, disruption, of both magic and technology. This much, he had surmised in his study of both her memories and that of her erstwhile commander. She would be invaluable in the cleansing of Etheria.

All the more so, if the young Queen kept the promise that had been extracted from her. No one was to know of her power, the wielder of She-Ra's might least of all. Given all that she- and therefore Prime- knew about the Queen, it seemed likely that she

would deign to grant the last request of the one who had “saved” her. Against all logic it might be, but that was so very typical of creatures that had not yet known Prime's light. All it had taken was to call her by name to make her agree without hesitation.

The Queen was to thank for more than that. Now that she knew of their true nature, it was a simple matter to actively practice controlling the weapons she had been born with. Prime had not yet presented her with a material that, with sufficient concentration and expenditure of energy, she could not at least damage. This had pleased him, and he was considering subjecting her to more intensive study to determine why and how this ability of hers functioned out of range of her homeworld's natural magic. Or, perhaps it was not magic at all, but a biological trick that could be replicated. It would be foolish to assume that the Etherian natives could tell the difference.

Testing of her deadlier ability would begin once the Velvet Glove reached Etheria. She looked forward to it. In the meantime, however, she had work to do.

“Hello, Adora.”

Catra grabbed Glimmer's shoulder, stopping just shy of sinking her claws into the pale fabric. That active control, that awareness of a part of herself she had always let be guided by instinct, was something she had retained. She wished she hadn't.

Glimmer whirled abruptly, knocking Catra's hand aside, but relaxed upon seeing it was only her.

Only her.

Only *Catra,* who had been their enemy for years. Catra, who deserved no pity or mercy from the woman before her. Catra, who had nearly gotten Adora killed mere hours ago. Catra, who Glimmer was looking at with *concern.*

Before Glimmer could speak, Catra rasped out, “Did you tell her?”

“No.”

If Catra had allowed herself to sag with relief, Glimmer would have tried to catch her. So she didn't allow more than a brief tremble. “Good. Thanks Spar- um, Glimmer.”

Glimmer looked at her strangely. This time it wasn't pity, but something else, likely equally as unwarranted and undeserved. “You can call me Sparkles if you want, Catra. I really don't mind.”

“Okay.”

Catra turned and starting walking- not stumbling, or staggering, or hobbling, but *walking,* dammit- back to her room. She'd have to step carefully around Adora, who had insisted upon falling asleep outside the door. If it had been anyone else, Catra would have assumed that they were guarding her like the prisoner she should be, but Adora no doubt had some other, unbelievably stupid reason.

“That's it?” rang out from behind her.

She didn't turn around. “What else is there?”

“Catra. Sit down.”

Catra did. It was more of a controlled fall, really. No, she wasn't following *orders,* she just... latched onto the excuse to rest without looking weak.

Without the force field separating them, she could hear in detail every tiny movement of Glimmer's as she closed the distance and settled into what had become their usual position. Their backs still didn't quite touch, but it was close.

“Here? Really? Anyone could-”

“Adora's asleep,” said Glimmer. “Bow's asleep. Even Entrapta's asleep, for once. Wrong Hordak is... as asleep as he gets, I think. It's just us. You should really be sleeping too, you know. Adora had to heal Bow from some pretty nasty injuries once. He spent most of the next four days in bed.”

“Right. When I detonated a bomb in his face.”

She could *feel* Glimmer wince. “Yeah.”

“What do you want, Sparkles?”

“For you to tell Adora yourself.”

“Absolutely not.”

“Catra. She thinks *Shadow Weaver* has the Garnet. It's not like anyone could trust her when she said she didn't. It's worrying Adora, not to mention the rest of the Rebellion. Things were bleak when they left, and I can't imagine it'll be better when we make it home.”

“That's not my problem. When Adora wakes up, I'm going to make her drop me off on the first planet we pass that won't kill me instantly.”

What was it with this woman and laughing at the worst moments? “No, you won't,” Glimmer managed once her chuckling faded. “There's not a force in this universe that could keep Adora from you, Catra. Don't you get that?”

No. She didn't. Those words made her want to dig her claws into something, the floor, the walls, herself, but Glimmer wasn't done. “Adora's going home. We're coming with her, and so are you. And then, you'll help us kick Prime's ass with those cool powers of yours that I am definitely not slightly jealous of. How's that sound, Horde scum?”

So that's it, then. It was Catra's turn to laugh, though it was more of a wheeze. She'd already guessed at the true reason for her

retrieval, but it was nice to have it confirmed.

This, she could understand. Catra was used to being a weapon pointed at the enemy. Did it really matter who that enemy was, or who would claim victory in the end? She was born to cause destruction. Once she was back on Etheria, her capacity for it would be greater than ever before.

Catra could work with that. And maybe until they reached Etheria, she could pretend... pretend like Adora had come back for her for some other reason.

“Yeah,” she said. “Alright.”

“Good.”

This time, for the first time, it was Glimmer that took her leave.

Chapter End Notes

I swear Adora will actually get to be a character, and that this fic will consist of something other than Glimmer and Catra... doing their Glimmer and Catra thing. Eventually.

Was Catra still forced to fall off the platform, given that Prime has a use for her now outside of baiting Adora? I'm going to say probably. I find it unlikely even in canon that Prime would have actually allowed Catra to die; if she did, he would lose his best way to control Adora.

Also, magicat headcanons. And general Etheria headcanons when it comes to the nonhuman sapients. Because why not. It may be magic, and yet I still feel the need to explain shit.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Get off her.

No.

“Um, Catra? Is everything okay?”

“Fine, Adora.”

“It's just that. Melog is kind of heavy. Were they always this heavy?”

Catra turned over, taking in the sight of her stupid, stubborn alien companion sprawled across her equally stupid, stubborn childhood friend. Who was, technically, also an alien. Funny how these things work out. “Pretty sure they decide how heavy they are. Also, you're She-Ra, idiot. You can throw tanks.”

“I'm not turning into She-Ra just to lift them off me. Also, you said they, um, mirrored you? So-”

“Sometimes they do what they want.” Catra turned back, ears twitching. That dumb, wide-eyed expression was back on Adora's face. “I already told them to get off. They said no.”

You don't want me to.

Shut up.

No.

I can make you.

You won't.

“What are they saying?”

Catra paused. Melog hadn't been vocalizing, not wanting to wake anyone up. “How could you tell I was talking to them?”

“...Just a guess.”

That was a lie, but she didn't feel like calling Adora on it. “They finally understand why I put up with you. It's because you're very comfortable to lie on.”

Too late, she realized that instead of deflecting with a joke, she'd left herself wide open. “Well... if that's the case... then why aren't you...” Adora's voice trailed off.

Catra shifted, letting one hand find where her bedroll ended and latch on. Grounding herself in the sensory. It was a trick Glimmer had taught her. One she'd apparently picked up from the flower princess.

You know her name.

This again. Melog didn't care what she called the others out loud, but they insisted, for some reason, that she refer to them with their actual names in her own head.

Fine. It's Perfuma. Now let me focus.

The rough stone beneath her knuckles, contrasted with the soft cloth of the sheets. The faint breathing of the others in the hideout. The subtle whispers of the remains of the fire, reduced to ashes and coals. The breeze slipping in from outside, ruffling her exposed fur, bringing with it the scent of the woods. The sudden, conspicuous absence of Melog's purr- yes, that was the term for it. Glimmer had told her.

Why wasn't she curled up with Adora? They'd shared a bed for nearly the entire trip home, Adora always finding some excuse or another, Catra always pretending to accept it at face value. Most of the time, Catra had found herself at the foot of the bed, too

skittish to come any closer. As if Adora would somehow sense the magic in her, the same magic that had made their lives hell as children.

The reason was simple. She couldn't bear to let herself have what she was going to lose. The more she distanced herself from it now, the less it would hurt when it was ripped away.

Catra had let herself believe otherwise for a while. It had been just her and Adora in their own little world on that ship. Well, Sparkles was there too, and Arrow Boy, and Entrapta, and even the clone. She could admit she'd grown to like being around- yes, yes, *Glimmer* and *Bow,* Melog. Something about them, so sickening and bright and cheery, helped drive away the shadows in a way even Adora couldn't always manage.

They were back on Etheria now. The shadows were everywhere. The shadows were *hers,* a force she could bend to her will. And the moment Adora found out, she'd never want to see Catra again.

It had been bad enough when it was dormant. Starved of magic. Now it blazed within her, threatening to shatter its chains at any moment. Lightning and shadows, destruction and pain. All she was, all she had ever been.

The magic, *her* magic, had burst out of her during the battle to retake Erelandia. Catra had been invisible, sneaking behind a squad of clones to attack from the rear, when she heard Adora's cry of distress from afar. In an instant, the lightning broke free, destroying Melog's illusion shielding her and cutting her off from her companion entirely. Alone and surrounded by enemies, she'd had no choice but to use it. The blood-red shockwave had surged outwards, and Catra shut her eyes tight at the first hint of it.

She'd heard the clones roar in pain. Upon daring to look, she even caught the last traces of agony showing on their faces before they settled into unconsciousness. In the moments after, she'd relived every time she'd felt that exact pain herself as she knelt on the

ground retching. At least once the crackling in her ears faded, the accursed power retreating for now, Melog's presence in her mind returned. They'd helped her remember how to breathe.

No one had seen. This time.

Catra wouldn't be able to hold it back forever. She couldn't. She needed to be the Rebellion's weapon. That was the deal, after all.

So it was inevitable that she would lose Adora. Again. Why would she torture herself, believing otherwise?

Yes. Why?

Because I deserve it.

She ignored Melog's disapproval and found an answer she could give Adora.

"I don't want to do that with everyone else around."

"Oh. Yeah. That's... that's fine. Sorry to bother you."

Catra gripped the edge of her bedroll a little tighter. "Just go to sleep, Adora."

"Okay. Um. Melog is still..."

Fine, you can stay there. Just let her sleep.

She heard Melog's purr start up again, then change in pitch as they shrank down to a more reasonable size.

"Thanks."

"Don't thank me," she grumbled.

"Right. Thanks, Melog."

The rumbling grew louder in response. Despite herself, Catra let it lull her to sleep.

“Hey, Catra~”

Catra hadn't bothered acknowledging Glimmer coming up from behind, but *that* got her attention. “Sparkles, what-”

Her world dissolved into pink fuzz, then reformed. She sank to her knees, stomach churning.

So much for getting a warning. Ugh. She'd always hated Glimmer's powers most- more than even Mermista's- and her opinion on them had not changed since switching sides. Something in her always felt like it had been turned upside down and inside out whenever she was subjected to the Moonstone's brand of teleportation.

Also, it was pink. Nothing that powerful should be that pink. She may not *like* Adora's golden-white aura, or the rainbow tinge that accompanied it, but at least it was properly imposing.

Her stomach settling, Catra stood, and found out where she stood. On a plateau, under an overcast sky. Somewhere in the mountains near Dryl, she was fairly certain.

She opened her mouth to complete her question. “Seriously, what the fuck-”

The dodge was an automatic response, her body twisting to the side and around before she could think, avoiding the raw blast of magic by a hair.

Oh, shit.

Glimmer stood facing her, staff extended, remnants of her power still sparking off her weapon. Her expression was deadened, unfeeling. Blank. Controlled.

No. No, no, no. This was bad. This was so very bad. How the hell had she gotten chipped? How long had Prime been puppeteering

her?

No time to wonder. Glimmer was already on the move, warping behind her and unleashing a barrage of searing light. At least this time, with proper warning, Catra could dodge forward rather than away. She had to get close. Hit the chip with enough force, and it would stop working at least long enough for Catra to... figure out something.

But the moment she came within one bound of her target, Glimmer's form fizzled into nothing and reappeared farther away. Catra was forced to avoid a series of low, sweeping arcs of radiance, then a torrent of flame from a hastily-drawn spell circle. Right. She was a sorceress too. Great.

This continued for some minutes. Glimmer standing her ground, a nightmare of light and heat and magic, while Catra weaved between her attacks. They were precise, robotic, always aiming at where she was rather than where she was going to be. Was Sparkles resisting? Was Prime still unused to magic? It hardly mattered. She needed every advantage she could get.

It wasn't enough. Over and over, Catra would start to close in, and Glimmer would vanish. She needed to attack at range, to stun Glimmer, to negate the overwhelming tactical advantage that was the Moonstone.

She had a way to do that.

Alright. This was going to suck, but maybe it would be worth it. The only thing worse than Adora learning what Catra had done would be Adora's face upon learning that they'd lost another ally to Prime.

And the only thing worse than that would be getting chipped herself and being forced to fight Adora. Never again.

Catra had wondered to herself a handful of times, out of annoyance with Sparkles or just plain boredom, which of them would have won if they had been allowed to fight it out in the

Fright Zone. Lucky her, she was going to get the chance to find out.

The Garnet's power came to her call.

Lightning surged from her claws first. Drawn to where her body was already used to wielding magic, perhaps. From there, it trailed up and around her, snapping and crackling, yet never making contact with her body.

The shadows did not come, and she did not ask for them. They would serve no purpose, and with the sky dully clouded, she wasn't even sure there was sufficient darkness to wield. Glimmer, or Prime, had chosen this battlefield well. There would be no escape, no striking from cover.

She was too far away for her connection with Melog to function. Still, Catra felt the dim traces of it drown under the static. For the best, really. She would need every scrap of concentration she could muster. And if Melog could still sense her, and let the others know something was wrong, they would have already done so.

Not that she could rely on backup. If anything, her opponent was the one likely to receive reinforcements. Clones, robots, even Prime's interceptors raining devastation from the sky. So far, at least, it was just the two of them.

Glimmer watched her carefully, maintaining a ready stance. More cautious, now. Sensible. Prime knew Catra posed a real threat to his new asset.

At least he wasn't possessing Glimmer directly. If he were, Catra would have to deal with his insufferable speeches coming from the mouth of a friend.

A friend. Sparkles had become that, hadn't she?

That was the thought Catra focused on as she, with a flick of her wrist, sent a jagged bolt of electricity towards Glimmer. Prime would not be permitted to hurt anyone she cared about. If she

had to suffer in the process, fine. If she had to be the one to hurt the people she cared about, and see them turn away from her for it, *fine.*

Glimmer was struck before she could teleport. Nausea rose once again as Catra saw pain show on Glimmer's face. It had to be just as intense as Catra remembered to break through the control-

Wait. Something was happening. Glimmer was steeling herself, planting her feet. The red static around her form began to shift, pooling upwards, leaving her body and latching onto her staff.

With a yell, Glimmer sent a burst of lightning right back at Catra.

As telegraphed as it was, it was simple to evade. Nevertheless, her hands trembled, remembering all the times she hadn't been able- or allowed- to avoid it.

“Come on, Catra. You'll have to try harder than that.”

Right. Spinnerella had talked too. And so had she, as little as Catra wanted to think about her time spent as Prime's slave. Some taunting was to be expected, but she was used to ignoring Glimmer's bluster.

All that mattered was the chip. Nothing else.

Try harder.

Fine. She would.

Catra charged, wreathed in lightning. It moved to her will, arcing between her claws, up and down her body. It spread through the ground at her feet, scorching the dust. It surged through the air, the smell of ozone overpowering all else.

She let herself *look,* and she found... her lightning wasn't like Shadow Weaver's. It was brighter. Faster. More concentrated.

And it didn't hurt. Not physically, not even as she drew upon more and more of the Garnet's energy. She'd thought it would. Shadow Weaver's strikes had cost her, cries of effort coming out in each movement as she fired off blasts of darkness coated in paralyzing electricity. How much of that was her own magic, her own status as a failed sorceress, her own choices? The old witch had certainly taken care to live up to her name. It made her intimidating, sure, but Catra had defeated her with over two years less combat experience than she had now.

Shadow Weaver had been a mere parasite, leeching off the Garnet. For whatever reason, the runestone had accepted Catra. The Black Garnet was hers, in a way it never had been Shadow Weaver's.

I can do whatever I want with this hunk of rock. Spiteful words from years ago echoed into the present with new meaning. She had a choice. Both in whether to use it, and in *how* she could use it.

For the first time, it occurred to Catra that someone with control over shadows had the ability to *cast them out*- wait, no, loaded phrase, never mind. She flinched, stumbling for a moment, and received some singed fur as a result. Right. Fight now, process personal revelations later.

Aside from that brief lapse, Catra had Glimmer on the run. She was blinking in and out, barely managing to counterattack. Catra sent forth streaks of lightning at unexpected angles, twirling and cracking it around her, mimicking the movements she had made with her long-discarded whip. Her whole body went into every motion, and her power followed those motions with ease and precision. What had once been a source of fear and suffering had become, at least for now, her own strength. Despite herself, she grinned.

It should have lasted longer. But less than a minute into their dance, Glimmer failed to discorporate in time. One bolt made

contact, and as she struggled to overcome the pain and paralysis, Catra struck again. And again. And again.

Glimmer fell, crumpling to a heap on the ground. Her struggles stilled, overwhelmed by the red static engulfing her. It was done.

Praying she was alright, Catra rushed to Glimmer's side, ready to free her of Prime's control. Or at least knock her out and let Entrapta do the rest. She dispelled the lightning, not wasting time thinking about how exactly to do that and instead simply making it so with her will and a single light touch. The moment it was gone, she shoved Glimmer over, eyes locking onto the back of her neck where the chip-

Wait.

There was no chip.

Glimmer teleported out from underneath her. Catra jumped backwards, bewildered, and Glimmer reappeared facing her.

She was smiling. Unsteady, and more than a bit scorched, but *smiling.* “Nicely done, Horde scum.”

Rage flared, made all the more intense by relief.

“Sparkles, I'm going to fucking kill you.”

“No you aren't.”

“Yes I am. What the hell was that?”

Glimmer leaned on her staff, suddenly serious. “Catra. If you'd fought at Erelandia, really fought, we'd have Spinnerella back. You know that.”

Glimmer wasn't accusing her. It was simply a fact being stated. Why? Her voice should be angry. Not... gentle.

It was dangerously close to pity, and it made Catra's claws itch.

“If I'd really been chipped just now, you would have freed me. My father, Spinnerella, Scorpia, Mermista, Sea Hawk... We'll get them back, and we need your help to do it, Catra.”

Who the hell was Sea Hawk? Whatever, didn't matter. Yeah, Catra was well aware that she was here to be a weapon. Had this just been a test of her capabilities? The equivalent to ensuring a Horde blaster was in working order so you could trust it to keep you alive in battle? “I fucking know. Why did you-”

Glimmer didn't let her finish. “Do you know what Shadow Weaver did to me, back when you kidnapped me for her?”

Catra tensed at the memory, but still, Sparkles didn't seem to be bringing this up to hang it over her head. Though what she *was* doing, Catra had no idea. “Adora said you were cursed.”

A nod, friendly and casual, as if they were just chatting. “I think she transferred a bit of the Garnet's power to me. It glitched out my own powers. And hurt. A lot. I managed to shake it off during the battle for Brightmoon by, well, using it. Unleashing it on someone else. On Scorpia, actually.” She winced, and so did Catra. “Point is, I've dealt with the Garnet's magic. I know what it does to people. And I'm not Shadow Weaver. Or Adora. Who you still need to *talk to,* but if you're going to be stubborn about it, then this will have to do. I can help. And you don't have to worry about it hurting me. After the Heart... well, you know. It doesn't compare. I can take it.”

It was true; the Heart had been worse than anything Shadow Weaver had ever done. At least in a purely physical sense. But that didn't explain anything. “Yeah, still missing why you *pretended to be chipped and attacked me,* Sparkles.”

“Because I know what it's like, Catra! Dealing with a power that's too much for you, that hurts you to use. That you don't think is yours, that doesn't feel like yours. I grew up sharing my runestone with my mom. I used to hate how limited I was. The weakest princess. But when she... left, and the Moonstone was

mine... Every time I used it, I was reminded of her. Every time I did more than just teleport, it felt wrong, and unnatural, and... bad. I always thought of my powers as... soft."

Without breaking eye contact, Glimmer let a fierce light build in her palm. "But no. My mom was shielding me from the destructive side of the Moonstone. And she never even used it herself, not really." A wistful smile appeared as the light disappeared. "I guess she didn't want to encourage me. I was a bit of a menace."

Glimmer took a deep breath, in and out. "But here's what I wish someone would have told me, Catra. This power is mine, and more importantly, it isn't evil. It's not good, either. That's determined by how I use it. Using it to save the people I care about... that makes it good. I had to learn this the hard way twice over. I don't want you to have to go through the same thing."

"...You're going to make a hell of a queen one day, Sparkles." Catra felt as if she were lost at sea, trying to piece together a raft from driftwood only for it to keep falling apart under her. She could understand the logic in what Glimmer was saying, and she'd gotten halfway there on her own, but something in her brain was refusing to fully accept it.

"I already am."

Catra didn't argue. Not with that, at least. "How do you expect me to ignore everything it's done to me? And to Adora? And to... you? And why do you even *care?* I'm... I'm here to fight Prime for you. That's why you brought me back. What does it matter how I *feel* about it?"

Glimmer stared at her, mouth agape, for some seconds. Then, she teleported, and before Catra could respond, Glimmer had her trapped in a hug. "*Catra.* We rescued you because it was the *right thing to do.* Because you saved me. Because Adora... because of how much Adora cares about you. Because you *deserve it.* Not so you could tear yourself apart fighting for us. I don't expect you to ignore your pain. I just want you to reach out when you're hurting

so we can help. That's how it works here on the side of the good guys, Horde scum. We help each other."

"Oh." She stopped struggling. Her arms twitched, some fragile part of her wanting to hold onto the friend that only minutes ago she thought she'd lost, but she forced the instinct and her hands down.

If Glimmer noticed, she didn't say. "And you call Adora the idiot."

"She is."

"She is," agreed Glimmer, releasing her and stepping back. "You like that about her."

Catra had nothing to say to that. "So. What now?" she asked, instead.

Glimmer shrugged. "The others shouldn't miss us for another couple hours. We have time to practice. Think you're up for it, *princess?*"

"Ew. No." Catra made a face. "I'll do it, just don't call me that."

"Very well, Your Highness." Smirking, Glimmer took another few steps back and raised her staff.

Catra felt static jump between her claws, and for once, she didn't mind. "Oh, you are *so* in for it, Sparkles-"

A shrill beeping sound cut them off.

Frowning, Glimmer retrieved her communicator pad from her side and switched it on. "What?"

"Glimmer!" Bow's voice was distorted both by the speaker and his own panic. "Are you okay?"

"...Yes?"

Catra had a bad feeling about this.

“I've been trying to reach you for the past few minutes. Is anyone with you?”

“Just Catra.”

“Grab her and get out. I've been monitoring Entrapta's tracker. There was another signal right next to you. A *runestone* signature. Mermista is up to something. Or I guess it could be Shadow Weaver? Don't risk it. Teleport back here *now.* I've already called the others back, we can go after her together-”

“Bow! Relax.” Glimmer looked up at Catra nervously. “We're fine. There's no one else here. It must have been, um, a glitch. I, uh, didn't know Entrapta could track princesses? Oh wait, now I remember. She said it didn't, er, work that well? Maybe she didn't tell you.”

There was silence. Catra glared. She had thought Sparkles was better than Adora at this, but evidently she'd been wrong.

“You're... you're lying.”

“Um,” said Glimmer.

Bow's voice hardened, just barely failing to disguise the tremor. “Show me your neck, Glimmer.”

“Bow, I'm not-”

“Show me your neck.”

Fuck this. Once Arrow Boy started crying it took him entirely too long to stop. Catra stepped up to Glimmer's side, into the communicator's view, and did a quick spin to show off the distinct lack of a chip on her neck.

“We're fine. It's just us. Sparkles kidnapped me. I suppose that's only fair, considering.”

Bow's titanic sigh of relief cut off halfway through. “Mermista is right on top of you two! Get out of-”

“Is anyone else around?” Catra interrupted. “You, I mean. Are you alone?”

“Um, no? I mean, yes, it's just me in here. Wrong Hordak and Melog are guarding the entrance. Look, I'm serious, I saw another runestone signal-”

“Yeah. Mine.”

“...What.”

Bow pinched the bridge of his nose. “So all along, it was you that took the Garnet.”

“Yeah.”

“And *you* knew.”

“...Yes.”

“And you didn't tell us because...?”

“Because I made her promise not to,” said Catra. “When I got her away from Prime. I *begged* her.”

Bow's eyes widened a bit. “Oh.”

“She thinks Adora will hate her if she finds out. And she thought we only got her back so she could be useful,” Glimmer chimed in. Fucking *snitch.*

Just like that, Bow was on the verge of tears again, turning to Catra. “You... That's not...”

“Spare me the waterworks, Arrow Boy. Sparkles already gave me the lecture. Apparently you all care about me or something. Pretty

embarrassing for you.”

Aaaand Bow had started crying. Dammit. She'd thought playing it off like that would dam the flood, but really, she should have known better.

She also should have known Entrapta would still have that tracker. Catra had been the one to make her build it, after Entrapta had just casually mentioned that she'd been studying Glimmer's magic. Somehow she'd captured one of the sparkles left in the wake of Glimmer's teleportation- the very thing that had prompted Catra's nickname for her- and in no time she'd managed to not just locate Glimmer herself, but any other runestone activity as well. Though Glimmer was the only one whose signature Entrapta could identify, and it couldn't locate the non-runestone princesses. Still, it had proven useful more than once over the years. It made sense that she would have shared it, and that someone slightly less distractible would be keeping an eye on it.

Melog's familiar presence nudged the edges of her mind.

The others are coming.

Thanks.

“Hey. Melog says we're about to have company.”

Glimmer nodded at her, then turned to Bow, who was still sniffling. “Alright, come on. Let's get you sorted out, you big dork. And don't worry, he won't tell anyone. That's *your* job.”

With that, she teleported herself and Bow away. Moments later, Catra heard the majority of the remaining Rebellion come storming in, calling for them.

Adora was calling for *her,* specifically, and the look on her face when Catra poked her head out made her want to either run away or right into Adora's arms. She split the difference and stayed where she was.

“Hey. False alarm. Everything's fine. Or as fine as it gets, I guess. Bow freaked out over nothing. Glimmer took him somewhere to calm down.”

She watched Adora nearly melt on the spot from relief. Her stupid horse tucked his wings back into his side. Frosta looked disappointed, letting her ice-covered fists drop. Entrapta, on the other hand, had confusion written all over her face, and Netossa and Perfuma were openly suspicious.

There was a hunted, haunted look in their eyes. It had been there since she'd first seen them after returning from space. Catra once again made a show of pointing out the scar where her chip had been. “There. Happy?”

Grumbling, Frosta and Netossa wandered out, along with- *no,* Melog, she was going to keep calling him “Adora's stupid horse.” She didn't like him, and he didn't like her, and that was *fine.* She did her best to forget he existed.

Entrapta's eyes practically lit up when Catra explained- lied about- why Bow had been in such a panic. “A glitch? Fantastic! I'll get to fixing it right away, if you can just give me details-”

“Erm, Entrapta?” Flower princess- *Perfuma*- to the rescue. “Shouldn't we be working on, you know, getting access to Prime's communications? The thing we just spent hours trying to figure out how to do?”

“I... suppose.” Entrapta's face and hair drooped. “But glitches are so *fun*...” She let herself be led away by Perfuma, still voicing her excitement at the prospect of hunting down a bug in her code.

Adora wasted no time in closing the distance between them once they were alone. Her eyes swept up and down, spotting the patch of singed fur. “You're hurt?”

“Sparkles took me out for a sparring session. Don't worry about it, princess. It's not even a real burn. There's nothing to *heal,*” she added with force, as Adora started to glow.

The light dimmed to reveal her best friend red with embarrassment. “Oh. Okay. If you're sure...”

She stared at Catra, then looked away. Shuffled her feet. Looked back. “Um. I'll go... erm. I should...”

“Out with it, Adora.”

“Well. It's just. Entrapta doesn't make that many mistakes.”

Oh fuck.

For all that she called Adora an idiot, Catra knew better than anyone that she wasn't. She really, really wasn't. There was a reason Catra had always fallen short of Adora's level back when they were cadets despite her inherent advantages. Adora noticed connections, patterns, her mind effortlessly stringing together stray bits of information into a complex matrix that she drew upon almost by instinct. Catra had always been faster than her, but what did that matter, if Adora knew where she was going to be before she did?

Now, sometimes she ended up with completely incorrect conclusions about what those patterns *meant,* or failed to recognize false information given to her. Case in point: she'd never noticed how Catra felt about her. Or how Glimmer felt about her, if Catra's suspicions were correct. Other case in point: it took watching a village be destroyed in front of her to realize the Horde was evil. She was hopelessly stubborn once she had decided on something, her mind carefully collecting and documenting every bit of evidence that supported her theory. If she'd actually figured it out, Catra was never going to be able to convince her otherwise, and this time Adora was spot on.

Catra knew that she didn't react. Melog, however, flared red in the corner of her eye, and Adora had already been looking their way.

That was her punishment from the universe, she supposed. Having her emotions laid bare for all to see.

She had never been one to accept punishment without fighting back. In a performance Double Trouble would applaud, she scoffed and raised an eyebrow. “I'm sorry, are we talking about the same person? Princess? Long purple hair that moves? Would chase a scrap of tech off a cliff if she thought it had interesting data on it?”

“Okay, fair,” Adora acquiesced. She chewed on her bottom lip nervously before speaking again. “But when her tech goes wrong it tends to, uh, blow up. Or attack us. Or... actually, it's pretty much always been one of those.”

Catra snorted. That, at least, was genuine. “She was the same in the Horde, believe me.” Right now, bringing up bad memories was far preferable to allowing any focus on the present.

Unfortunately, Adora wasn't to be distracted so easily. “Entrapta doesn't make *small* mistakes. If there really were two runestone signals... and you were 'sparring' with Glimmer...”

“Who *teleports,*” Catra said. The air was starting to feel thin. “If she had moved fast enough, there'd probably have been a dozen signals.”

“I think Entrapta would have accounted for that.”

Shit. She- she wasn't- she wasn't ready to do this. Even if Adora- even if- if-

You need time.

When had Melog made their way to her side? They were small, mane still flaring red, but they looked up at her calmly.

Ask for time.

“Adora, I...”

“It's okay, Catra.” This didn't make sense. How could Adora possibly still stand to look at her? Much less like *that?* “Do you

have anything to tell me?”

She took a deep breath. “No. Not... now.”

“Alright.” Suddenly, Adora swept her into a hug, and despite her agitation- or perhaps because of it- Catra let out a brief purr before Adora released her. “You let me know if that changes?”

“...Yeah.”

Adora smiled. “Sounds good. I'm gonna go take Swifty for a ride, I haven't got a chance since we got back. I don't suppose you'd, uh, like to come along? I don't even think you two have talked yet. We should probably stick to the ground anyway.”

Dazed but relieved, replying almost on automatic, Catra made a disgusted face. “No. Absolutely not. Keep your awful talking rainbow horse away from me, thanks.”

Adora just laughed, her first real laugh since they'd come home, and something in Catra's chest ceased to be bound by gravity. “Alright. See you later, then. Watch her back, Melog.”

Melog let out an agreeable *mrrow.* Their mane had returned to a cool blue.

As she watched Adora go, Catra thought of what Glimmer had said, weeks and worlds away.

There's not a force in this universe that could keep Adora from you, Catra. Don't you get that?

She still didn't. But maybe she was starting to.

Chapter End Notes

> Yeah, Sea Hawk got chipped alongside Mermista and Scorpia. Scorpia didn't have the kind of power necessary to keep both the crowd and her at bay, so Sea Hawk stepped in to keep Mermista distracted. The only thing I regret about this

decision is that it means Double Trouble didn't get to flirt with him. As much.

Entrapta capturing one of Glimmer's sparkles and then promptly using it to build a tracker appears to be canon. As in, she definitely did the first thing, and that's the best explanation for Lonnie later having a device that showed Glimmer's teleportation. Extending it to Entrapta being able to track any runestone activity, but only identify Glimmer specifically, wasn't much of a leap.

Also. I only realized while writing this that Glimmer never uses her staff in the last season. She sends it away before going to try to destroy the Garnet, and it doesn't show up again. As mentioned, I'm playing close to canon in this story, both in plot and aesthetic, and would be willing to fall in line with it if there were a good reason *why* she never uses it. But there isn't, so I'm giving it back.

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A number of princesses were currently occupying Catra's shit list.

Glimmer, for kidnapping and attacking her. Okay, *maybe* it had ended up helping with the whole Garnet thing, but whatever.

Netossa, for spraying her with water and making her look like an idiot in front of everyone, and more importantly, Adora.

Perfuma, for playing the *you were a bitch to Scorpia* card to win an argument. Not that she wasn't right, Catra had just gotten used to tuning out whenever anyone talked about Scorpia. It was either that or collapse into a puddle of shame and self-hatred.

Glimmer again, for not coming on this mission. Honestly, Sparkles, what the hell. She was their second strongest fighter, she could go on a date with Arrow Boy some other time. *No, shut up, Melog. I'm mad at them, I get to-* Oh, right. They couldn't hear her right now, or she them.

Entrapta, for building Scorpia a fucking *rocket hammer* along with a robotic hand to replace her ruined left pincer and not thinking that was an important thing to mention. It would have been nice to know- wait. This one might be her fault, what with her ignoring anything to do with Scorpia. Shit. Alright, scratch that, Entrapta was fine.

The latest addition to the list was Mermista. Now, usually, being chipped would make her exempt, but Catra was *pissed.*

It was pretty obvious why Prime had sent the water princess after her, and not just because Catra hated water. She and Prime both knew quite well that she wasn't immune to electricity. It was difficult to ensure that she could attack Mermista without getting

shocked herself, but between the ample darkness of the Fright Zone and Melog, she'd managed to get some distance and land what should have been the first of the finishing blows.

But no. Mermista had somehow managed to insulate herself, about which Catra could only think *what the fuck.* How was that fair? Or even possible?

She leapt up to the next level of the slowly-drowning prison complex, keeping to the shadows both natural and summoned, and watched her foe carefully.

Mermista was enveloped in a rotating sphere of water, spinning just below the surface. It made her form almost impossible to discern, but Catra caught the glint of those unnatural green eyes. Scanning the few remaining floors for her, no doubt.

Catra backed away into a cell, out of sight, and let the Garnet's power fade. *Melog.*

Here.

Her companion materialized briefly at her side before vanishing again. One thing that Catra didn't have to worry about was hurting Melog by accident, even when they couldn't sense her. Melog was, after all, more than a mere shapeshifter. Some basic rules of the universe were more like guidelines for them. Guidelines that could be ignored. Things like gravity. Or the need for any particular corporeal form. If Krytis had once been full of creatures like them, she could see why Prime had been forced to retreat.

Can you get close? Tell me what you see?

Yes.

Her eyes, sharp as they were, spotted a faint trail of sparkling mist stream out of the cell. She didn't think Mermista would notice. Sure enough, she felt Melog rematerialize elsewhere for

just a moment. Probably clinging to the central control station, as yet not completely underwater.

When Melog attempted to relay complex information, it sort of... fuzzed out. Catra would get the general idea along with disorganized scraps of phrases. This was one of those times.

Two... held apart... separation... water within water.

Shit. Mermista's personal bubble- or whatever the opposite of a bubble is called- was being held separate from the rest of the rising flood, empty air serving as a shield. Catra wasn't certain to what extent her magical lightning obeyed the rules of ordinary electricity, which were something anyone who spent any amount of time around Entrapta had to learn for their own safety. One way or another, Mermista's improvisation was keeping her safe. How could Catra possibly manage to beat her, when getting close meant both giving Mermista an overwhelming advantage and making her own powers turn against her?

The answer stared her in the face as Melog returned to her side. Could she actually do it? Without breaking her own body- or mind- in the process? She was already worn down enough as it was.

She was pretty sure Scorpia had bruised some ribs. The blow that sent her flying had been on par with one from She-Ra during their worst fights. Not that Catra would ever admit this, especially to Glimmer, but she did feel a bit stupid for never noticing that she was a decent bit sturdier than your average Etherian. Considering most Horde soldiers had crumpled like cardboard when faced with She-Ra, she probably should have realized that even if Adora had been being her stupid sentimental self and going easy on her, Catra had no business taking the hits she did and getting right back up. That included all that Shadow Weaver had done to her when she was small. It had been painful, yes, but it hadn't done any lasting physical damage.

Maybe it was time she relied on that.

She wasn't as tough as Scorpia. Pretty much no one was as tough as Scorpia. It was probably a good thing that it was Adora *and* Perfuma *and* Netossa there to deal with her. Though if Spinnerella were here too, or worse, *Micah...*

Eh. Adora would probably win anyway. That was She-Ra for you.

Her victory, on the other hand, was less than assured. This was not a fun plan.

Prime knew her. Or, he knew Catra as she had been, what Catra had thought of herself at the time. She had always played to her strengths. Never taking on a foe directly. Using her environment and superior agility to her advantage. Dodging, observing, calculating, until she identified the right moment to strike. And, most of all, never doing anything that would make her face her weaknesses.

And her weaknesses? First off, water, which Netossa had just *somehow known.* Wait, had Adora told her? Had Adora told *everyone?*

Rude. Sure, she'd all but given lectures to her troops on She-Ra's weak points, but there was a difference between pointing out openings in an opponent's fighting style and disclosing her *very personal* dislikes, *Adora.*

Focus.

Oops. Banishing thoughts of Adora from her mind, Catra let Melog cloak her as she crept towards the ledge. She narrowed her eyes at Mermista. She could see it too, now, the double layers of water keeping the princess safe from electrocution. There were only a couple levels left to go before the whole complex would be underwater. She was running out of time.

Prime was about to get one hell of a surprise. She took a deep breath, told Melog to get some distance just in case, and leapt off the ledge.

The moment she hit the water, her invisibility failed. Not that it mattered. Mermista was on her in the blink of an eye, a hand latching onto her neck. Catra clawed at it, blood seeping from multiple wounds, but Mermista held firm as she propelled the two of them through the water at speed and slammed Catra against the wall.

Her face wasn't blank. Instead, the unchecked rage in Mermista's expression, clearly visible now that she'd dismissed her barrier, was matched only by the force of her hand around Catra's throat.

That might have something to do with Salineas. Or the wreckage that had once been Salineas.

"What now, *Catra,*" she heard Mermista hiss out, muffled and distorted through the water. "Surrender, and you may yet earn Prime's forgiveness through servitude. There is no escape. Prime sees all, Prime knows all. You cannot hurt me without hurting yourself."

Yeah. That was the idea. She grabbed Mermista's arm with both hands, latched on, and let the Garnet's power- no, her power- build within her. Far more than she'd ever used before, rising and crackling until she felt like she was about to burst.

She set the lightning free, and the world went red.

Catra didn't let herself fall unconscious. She felt every bit of the pain as electricity coursed through and around her. She held on even as Mermista's struggles grew weak. Even as the water receded, depositing both of them onto slippery metal. Even as her hearing, her sight, her mind fizzled into nothing. Even as Mermista finally released her, and Catra could breathe again, she *held on.*

Until she couldn't any more. She collapsed, Mermista's limp weight dragging her down, the two of them splaying out side by side on the walkway.

It was some minutes before Catra started to regain her senses. Or maybe it was an hour. Or maybe only a few seconds. Hearing first,

the rush of water now far below. Then the horrid sensation of wet fur covering her whole body. The awful taste in her mouth. The smell of scorched hair and fur. The faint echo of Melog's concern in her mind. And of course, pain. That of the present moment, and of the past.

Glimmer was right. It still didn't compare to what the Heart had done to them. Mermista had experienced that too, even if she didn't have years of exposure to the Black Garnet's specific brand of torture. Catra had to move.

She dragged herself upright, digging her claws into the metal of the wall for support. Still bleary-eyed, she forced herself to focus on Mermista.

There was the chip. That was all that mattered. It was flickering, failing. One more blow-

She was so focused she didn't recognize the sound of someone rushing towards her until they kicked her right off the ledge. In her shock, she only caught the briefest glimpse of his face.

Catra fell, twisting in midair. A few stories down, she managed to catch her claws on a lift and haul herself on.

She looked up. Mermista and her savior were gone.

Fuck.

Once she had taken a minute more to recover, Catra started making her way back to where the others had been. Melog padded along at her side. Hopefully, by now, three princesses had managed to subdue their single opponent. Even if one of them was still insisting on trying the diplomatic approach.

They had not, in fact, managed to subdue Scorpia. Netossa was nowhere to be found, and Adora- untransformed- was kneeling in Hordak's old throne room, right next to Perfuma. The two of them

were bound by pulsing, flowing shadows. Dark magic. Catra drew in a breath as she took in the scene, thankful for Melog hiding her from sight.

Scorpia stood before her captured allies, hammer held at her side. The weapon was almost as tall as she was. Behind her stood a man who could only be Micah. Glimmer's father. And, judging by the chill in the air and the pall over his skin, not to mention the deep purple rune he held in his palm, a dark sorcerer to rival or even surpass Shadow Weaver at her strongest.

But the worst part was the gleam in his eyes. The pale light behind the green.

Prime was here, wearing the face of a man who was as much slave as hostage. And Perfuma was still going on about friendship.

"I've heard enough. End this, now." Prime turned away.

Scorpia took a step forward and lifted her massive weapon in her one hand. Just how strong had Entrapta made that thing? Whatever, *not* what she should be concentrating on right now.

There would be an opening before Scorpia struck. She had to make use of it, with whatever strength she had left. Perfuma pleaded, Adora stared listlessly, and Catra waited for her moment.

Scorpia swung her hammer up, staring down at Perfuma and Adora without the faintest hint of emotion.

Now.

The moment before she landed, she saw Scorpia hesitate. Then Catra slammed into her, lightning flooding from her claws and into Scorpia's body.

Scorpia toppled over with all the gravitas of a felled tree. Springing off her, Catra slashed at the chains of darkness holding Adora and Perfuma, and at her electrified touch they fell apart.

She may not be able to control these particular shadows directly, but she could still tear them to shreds.

“Hey, Adora.” She offered her idiot a hand up, ears pricked for Prime's retaliation. “Why the fuck aren't you transformed?”

Adora's shock at her appearance was different from Perfuma's. Perfuma was surprised, horrified, even a little angry, which Catra had only recently learned she was capable of. Adora, however, was looking at her with what Catra was pretty sure was *awe.*

Then, it was gone, leaving Catra to wonder if she'd imagined it as Adora climbed to her feet. “Thanks for the rescue.” She looked behind Catra and tensed, then sprung past her, sword appearing in her hand.

“For the honor of Grayskull!” Oh, good, She-Ra was back. Which was a thought that not too long ago would have been laced with sarcasm.

The rush of golden light made Perfuma overcome her shock. “No! Don't fight her! We can still-”

“Sorry, flower princess, but I tried it your way and got smacked to the other end of the Fright Zone. You tried it and almost got flattened, twice. Get somewhere safe and call Glimmer. We'll handle them.”

Protests followed. Catra cut them off with a snarl.

“You're useless around Scorpia,” she snapped. “And you've never fought anyone like Micah. Adora and I aren't, and we have. Get her out of here, Melog.”

Perfuma narrowed her eyes, but nodded curtly before vanishing. Catra turned in time to see Scorpia, already back on her feet, break off her struggle with Adora and take up a position next to Micah. To Prime, who was regarding them both with amusement, hands clasped behind his back.

“Well done, I must say.” Catra's ears flattened at the all-too-familiar cadence. “I'm impressed, little sister. It truly is a shame that you were stolen from my light. I will... regret having to destroy you. As for *this* one,” Prime waved a hand in Adora's direction, “as I've said, I have little use for her. She will go the way of the rest of her people, and I will permit myself the satisfaction of a task completed.”

“I'm not your little sister, jackass, and we're going to free every last person you've chipped. Starting with these two.” As much as she hated hearing Prime's stupid voice, getting him talking gave them more time to prepare and more time for Perfuma to get ahold of Glimmer.

“No,” Prime hummed, “I don't think you will. This vessel is a powerful one indeed. Perhaps not enough to stand against the likes of She-Ra, but it seems you're having some difficulty holding onto her, *Adora.* Could it be that-”

Catra tuned him out. “We have to make this fast,” she murmured to Adora, not taking her eyes off Prime. “I got Mermista, but it took a lot out of me.”

“You freed her?”

“No. Almost. Some chipped guy kicked me halfway down the prison block and ran off with her. He had an awful mustache.”

“That would be Sea Hawk.” Adora swore. “Should have guessed- shit, here they come. Let's go. Leave Prime to me?”

“Not a chance.”

She and Adora were fighting side by side. Maybe not quite as equals, but as close as Catra could hope to get. How long had it been?

They'd both changed so much since their days as Horde cadets, but their fundamental fighting styles remained the same. They knew each other, their moves, their tactics, their weaknesses. Catra found herself covering for Adora without so much as a word exchanged. Adora did the same, automatically stepping in when Catra needed help to create an opening.

With every energized swipe of her claws cutting away at the tendrils of darkness Prime sent at her from every direction, Catra became more and more aware that she was approaching the limits of what the Garnet could do. Or, at least, the limits of what she could handle. With her having to dig deeper and deeper each time she drew out the power within her, something indefinable being stretched painfully thin, there would be no striking down either of their opponents from afar.

Her movements felt slow, aching muscles protesting, damp fur weighing her down. Still, slow for her was more than fast enough to deal with Prime.

It was an eerie mirror of her "spar" with Glimmer. When she drew close, Micah would erupt into purple-black flames and reappear elsewhere. Catra had to keep moving; the living darkness Prime commanded, the inky strands of magic that reached for her and sapped her already dwindling strength, had melded with the natural shadows looming everywhere. There was no way to tell where an attack would come from next.

Wait a moment.

Of course there was.

Catra waved a hand, and the shadows of Hordak's old throne room receded into themselves, leaving the dark magic spreading from Micah in plain view. It gave their surroundings a surreal, almost painted look, but it served its purpose. There would be no attempts at subterfuge for Prime, no hiding in darkness. The darkness was hers to control, hers to summon, hers to banish.

Prime said something. Catra ignored it. She met Adora's eyes briefly; surprise and delight were expressions she was unused to seeing on She-Ra's features. Then again, she also wasn't used to seeing a golden imitation of her old mask staring back at her. It wasn't a bad look.

Throwing herself back into the battle, Catra pounced claws-first, easily slicing through an attempt to trip her up now that she could see it coming. Micah barely escaped in time. Above, having ascended the stairs leading up to Hordak's throne, Adora parried Scorpia's hammer in a show of raw strength only She-Ra could have managed. The next swing she gracefully dodged, letting it smash the throne to bits. Good riddance.

The massive weapon briefly got stuck in the rubble, and Adora took the opportunity to strike at Scorpia's back, only to have to swerve to avoid her stinger. At least there wasn't any attempt at conversation going on. Scorpia was completely blank, more so than their other chipped friends.

Catra knew what Adora was about to do. Knew that Adora would have spotted the same opening. Another leap forced Micah into She-Ra's sights, exactly where he needed to be. He drew a circle, a quick, practiced motion, but Catra was faster. She slashed through the rune, the sparks trailing from her claws dissipating the magic before it could activate.

Scorpia had unbalanced herself, the counterweight of her tail disrupted by her hasty attempt to strike at Adora. It was simple matter for She-Ra to shove her sideways, off the ruins of the throne and onto the floor below. Without hesitating, Adora took hold of Scorpia's fallen hammer and with one hand sent it hurtling towards Prime.

She hadn't thrown it with much force; if she had, it could have killed Micah. The handle of the weapon striking him between the shoulder blades was more than enough. He stumbled forward with a choked gasp. The hammer thudded to the ground uselessly.

A split second later, Catra had him pinned, her claws around his wrists. What power she had left was held at the ready to counter the first sign of spellcasting. Next to her, She-Ra had restrained Scorpia, one hand holding her remaining pincer against her back and the other gripping Scorpia's tail just below the stinger.

She wasn't sure when it had happened, but something had changed in Micah's eyes. The pinprick of light was gone, leaving the green. Prime had let go of his puppet's strings. Only the chip remained.

Micah spoke, his inflection very different, though no less hostile. “So, you're the reason my Angella is lost.”

Catra froze. She heard Adora gasp, and out of the corner of her eye, she saw the form of She-Ra flicker.

That was all it took. With a grunt of effort, Micah broke free of her grip and thrust out a hand. Instantly, a deluge of black flames engulfed him and Scorpia.

One last desperate torrent of lightning, the swift downward slash of a glowing sword. Both failed to stop Micah in time. He and Scorpia melted into the ground, the dark magic whisking them away. No doubt at the cost of further corrupting Glimmer's father.

They'd escaped.

Dammit.

There was no time. Prime could beam down an army of clones, or send more chipped sorcerers after them, or even throw Mermista back into the fray if she'd recovered. Catra turned to... Adora. She-Ra was gone. “We need to get out and find the others. Melog is with Perfuma.” She paused, a rush of information coming through the connection with her companion as the shadows reasserted themselves. “She just got through to Glimmer. Where's Netossa?”

Adora blinked, and it took her two tries to speak. “She... she ran after Spinnerella.”

“Do you know where- wait. Are you okay? Prime said something about-”

“I'm fine,” Adora lied.

“No you aren't. I don't exactly have the high ground when it comes to, uh, telling people about my problems,” she raised a hand, letting the smallest spark- all she could manage- jump from one claw to another, “but if you're-”

She didn't get to finish. Catra had barely registered the chime that signaled Glimmer's arrival before she was swept away back to their hideout.

It took a while for things to settle. Long enough for Catra to get herself mostly dry. Netossa arriving with Spinnerella in tow prompted an... interesting... conversation with Perfuma, who didn't even say a word about what she'd seen Catra do. She didn't seem to care, all her emotions from earlier resolved into a calm gentleness. That was a pleasant- if a little overwhelming- surprise, but Catra had a sneaking suspicion that the other, far less relaxed personalities among their allies might not respond quite as well.

After helping carry Spinnerella to where Entrapta was ready to operate, Adora healed Catra of her various bruises and burns, and then refused to leave her side. Glimmer did the same, even if she didn't invade Catra's personal space like *some* people. Bow stuck around too, briefly chatting with Wrong Hordak before the clone retired for the night. Apparently Prime had some way of letting his clones disregard the need for sleep, but with his connection to the hivemind long lost, Wrong Hordak required rest just like anyone else. Perfuma took her leave as well, following his example.

When it was just the five of them, Adora cleared her throat, and Catra absolutely did not trust or like the smirk on her face that

grew into a grin.

“So. Should I call you Princess Catra?”

Before Catra could do more than match Melog's growl, Glimmer's sigh of relief echoed throughout the cavern. “Fucking *finally,*” she muttered. “Longest weeks of my life.”

Adora's gaze snapped away from Catra. “Wait, you've known for *how long?*"

“Adora.” Catra shook her head and met Adora's eyes as they turned back in her direction. “I, uh. Sort of. Took the Garnet so I could attack Sparkles. And I almost did, but the Heart kicked in. So yeah, she knew from the start. And then I made her promise not to tell.” She raised her voice. “And Sparkles? Adora figured it out yesterday. You are *such* a bad liar.”

“Wha- I didn't even talk to her!”

“Yeah, but I had to go with *your* stupid story! She knew Entrapta wouldn't have made a mistake like that, and thanks to-”

Too late, she picked up the sound of approaching footsteps. The rest of the currently conscious Rebellion had returned, and two-thirds of their number were looking at Catra suspiciously.

The remaining third clapped her hands. “Oh! Are we talking about how Catra is the wielder of the Black Garnet?”

Netossa and Frosta did a double take, staring first at Entrapta's smiling face and then at Catra.

Adora tensed and moved ever so slightly in front of her. With a roll of her eyes, Catra gave her a tap on the leg with her tail. The silent message received, Adora reluctantly retreated back to her side. Catra refused to hide from this mistake any longer, and wasn't going to allow Adora to shield her from it. That was part of *keeping her heart open,* right?

It hurt, but she found she could handle it.

Frosta was the first to recover. “I'm going to punch her.”

“Please don't,” said Adora.

“Care to explain, Entrapta? And if she's right, *care to explain, Catra?*" Netossa crossed her arms.

“It's simple, really.” Entrapta's pigtails waved in the air as she gesticulated with her arms, one narrowly missing Netossa. “I went to find the glitch in the runestone tracker, and guess what! There wasn't one! That must mean that the signal it picked up was coming from Catra, and that she and Glimmer have been keeping it secret. I'm sure they have a good reason!”

“Do they now.”

“I'm going to punch *both* of them.”

Catra sighed and took a seat on a crate, curling her tail around her. “I think we have some explaining to do, Sparkles.”

“I am blameless in this debacle.”

“Maybe. Help me anyway?”

“Fine. I guess.”

To her surprise, it didn't take that much to make Netossa and Frosta calm down. Entrapta butting in every thirty seconds with questions for Catra about the Garnet probably helped lighten the mood. Netossa was too tired to muster much more than a passing irritation that Catra hadn't helped at Erelandia. Soon enough, she left to be at her wife's bedside. As for Frosta, she just insisted that she wouldn't be calling Catra a princess. Catra was more than fine with that.

After Frosta stomped out and Entrapta wandered off, Catra looked at Glimmer. “Hey, Sparkles. You know what would have made this mission way easier? If you'd been there from the start. I just got told off for not helping at Erelandia, what's your excuse for today?”

Instead of getting mad, Glimmer stuck her tongue out. “You think that now, but wait until you hear what we found.”

Adora's eyes grew wider and wider as Bow explained, Glimmer performing the important duty of being smug about having *their* mission go so well. At least that was what she started doing, before she ended up doing the same thing as Catra: staring at Adora.

Catra had known she was in love with Adora since she was six years old. Before she had ever even heard the word “love,” much less knew what it meant. In that time, she'd watched Adora take on burden after burden. Catra had certainly added a few herself. The weight on Adora's shoulders had never stopped growing, and the moron never knew how to say no or take a moment to relax.

In Adora's shining face, Catra saw the reason she'd fallen for her. A trace of the girl she had been, once upon a time, and the woman she still could be. Brilliant, excitable, determined, and practically overflowing with love for everyone and everything.

At least Catra knew how to hide her reaction, unless you counted Melog purring up a storm from their perch above. Sparkles, on the other hand, had never known an Adora who wasn't trying to personally deal with every problem in the world. Judging by her flushed cheeks, she liked what she saw.

Catra expected to feel a spike of jealousy, but it didn't come. After all, it's not like Adora was ever going to notice either of them. What did it matter? Having Adora back as her friend... shouldn't that be enough for her? She hardly deserved what she had, asking for more would be asking to be hurt. She'd caused herself enough pain today, thanks. Just because Catra was going to try to

keep whatever remained of her heart open didn't mean that she was going to invite someone to break it all over again.

Melog abruptly stopped purring. They leapt down and nudged her, on the leg and in her head. Catra ignored them.

Adora had told her about Mara. She knew exactly why Adora was so affected by learning that Mara hadn't been fighting alone, almost more so than discovering a safe way to disable the Heart. Both were worth celebrating. Whatever problems Adora was having with She-Ra, she'd sort it out. They'd free everyone. Horde Prime and his overinflated ego would be wiped from the universe for good. Maybe... maybe they could really do this. Maybe she would be okay.

It was a nice thought, one so strange it was almost unsettling.

And naturally, the exact moment Catra let herself believe that, Shadow Weaver chose to make her entrance.

As she approached, Catra wrestled with every instinct to fight, to flee. To cower in terror. She had no *reason* to fear Shadow Weaver. Putting aside her own capabilities, Melog was at her side, now almost her height at the shoulders and snarling at her old tormentor. Adora- her brief moment of peace gone- didn't seem thrilled to see Shadow Weaver either, and Glimmer had promised that the dark sorceress would pay for her crimes.

All of that ceased to matter when Shadow Weaver looked at her. Even with those cruel eyes hidden behind the mask, Catra felt her insides turn to ice.

She knows.

Chapter End Notes

> Things were getting better. Shadow Weaver is here to make them worse. That is what she does best.

Adora did not, in fact, tell anyone that Catra hated water. It's a well known magicat thing.

Wrong Hordak is completely missing from the two episodes before the finale. I have made an effort to include him, albeit in a very minor role, for the same reasons I let Glimmer have her staff back. Though in this case I do understand why he wasn't in those two episodes. He had absolutely no place in them, and they had a hell of a lot to cover in a short time.

Scorpia gets a rocket hammer because it just seemed the obvious thing to do. Like, it wasn't even something I had to think about. Scorpia loses a pincer and gets a hand in return? Of course she gets a rocket hammer. I'm currently envisioning it looking something like Reinhardt's. (Entrapta didn't get a chance to make it scorpion-themed before Scorpia got chipped.)

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It had all come apart so fast.

Catra should have made Shadow Weaver stay at camp, by force if necessary, and let Glimmer's annoying aunt guide them. Though it was a bold assumption that Catra would have been able to. Glimmer pulled her aside as they were preparing to go and warned her that Shadow Weaver knew how to drain power from princesses. Sure enough, when Catra shocked her after the old witch dared to lay a hand on her, there had been no obvious effect. If anything, Shadow Weaver breathed a little easier than usual during their march through the catacombs.

She'd lied to Adora. She didn't come along just to keep an eye on Shadow Weaver. Catra went because she had let herself believe that, if it looked like Adora was going to do something stupid and heroic and get herself killed, she would be able to step in and stop her. That Adora would listen to her. That Adora would trust her. They'd come so far; she'd really thought that when push came to shove, Adora would take her side.

She'd failed. Completely and utterly. While Catra and Glimmer had battled Micah- who was somehow an order of magnitude more powerful than she'd seen him last, mere hours ago- Adora had gone and signed her life away.

Adora didn't care about herself. She never had. Catra knew Adora did care about her. Just not enough to care about herself for Catra's sake. She was willing to die for Catra, for *anyone,* but not to live for her.

And all Catra had ever done was live for Adora.

So she ran.

She'd tried to let Melog stay with Adora. Obviously *they* wanted to, because she sure didn't. In the end, however, her companion had followed her.

At least that meant she was able to take her anger out on some of Horde Prime's patrols. Catra couldn't use the Black Garnet, lest Adora track her down.

Did Prime know it was her doing? She hoped so. Catra spent hours slinking through the Whispering Woods, becoming the sort of nightmare she had once been told they contained. Clones and drones alike fell to her claws. None ever detected her in time.

It was a pointless exercise. It didn't even make her feel better. She kept at it anyway.

She hated herself for leaving Adora and for being so quick to go back to hating herself. She hated Adora for leaving her. She hated Glimmer and Bow for not helping her stop Adora. She hated Mara for failing and passing the burden onto Adora. She hated the whole Rebellion, all these people that had made Adora feel like she was their only hope. That if she didn't do it, no one would.

Most of all, she hated Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver had raised them. Manipulated them, controlled them. Only now did she understand that they never stood a chance against her machinations. How could they? She'd worked to mold them into her puppets every step of the way, encouraging their worst traits and ensuring that a few words from her could break them down or build them up. How could they fight back against someone like that? No. The only thing to do was run from her, and this time, Adora was the one unwilling to do so.

The moment she'd reappeared, Catra had fallen back into her old patterns. She'd even had to suppress nonsensical flares of jealousy as, once again, Shadow Weaver overlooked her in favor of Adora. For fuck's sake, Catra had become more powerful than Shadow Weaver had ever been. What more did she want?

Nothing would ever be enough for her. And Catra shouldn't care.

She still did.

Her swath of destruction only came to a halt when light began to flood over the horizon. By sheer coincidence, or so she told herself, Catra ended up near the Crystal Castle. She climbed a tree and found a comfortable position to rest among the branches. Melog would wake her if anyone- friend or foe- came by.

The last stars had faded before she managed to fall into a restless sleep.

Catra was up before noon and went right back on her rampage.

Prime's forces were prepared for her now, but that hardly mattered. Sure, clones were stopping to investigate every tiny irregularity, and she had to be a little more careful and find cover after striking lest she get picked off by cover fire. That only made it more fun. Every time she brought down a clone, she imagined that Prime could feel their pain.

It still didn't help.

And while she was resting between raids, someone appeared in front of her with a rush of magic.

“How the hell did you find me?”

Glimmer didn't dignify that with a response, choosing instead to keep glaring at Catra.

“Right,” Catra muttered. “Princess *and* sorceress. And I thought She-Ra was overpowered.”

“Says the princess who has a magic shapeshifting alien pet that can turn her invisible.”

“I'm not a- Melog's not a- whatever. What the fuck do you want, Sparkles?”

“What I *want,* Catra, is for you to stop throwing a tantrum and come back to us.”

Catra scrambled back a few steps and eyed Glimmer suspiciously. “If you try to make me-”

“But that's not what I *need,* Catra. I only need you to talk.” Glimmer sat down, the anger in her expression dissipating. “Please?”

Really? Now?

Talk to her.

Fine.

Catra made to move behind Glimmer, but was stopped by a hand grasping hers, just for a moment before letting go. “No. Face me this time.”

“Alright.”

The two of them stared at each other. Melog looked on, the whispers of their concern creeping into Catra's mind.

“Did Adora send you?”

“No. She told me not to go after you. I didn't listen.”

Oh. “Why not?”

“Because she's the same kind of stupid you are. She never asks for what she needs. I... I know I can't claim to know her as well as you do. But I do know her in a way you don't. I know who Adora is without Catra.”

Catra felt a lump in her throat begin to form.

Glimmer went on. “The day we met, she was so full of life. I was a jerk to her, but I couldn't help but think that it made perfect sense that she was She-Ra. Even being a Horde soldier. She nearly cried the first time she ate real food, did you know that? She was... she was *better* than me. A better person. A kinder person.”

Catra knew that feeling, but she couldn't speak.

“And then the Horde attacked Thaymor, and that Adora died. A soldier took her place. She was still *Adora,* just with her love for life replaced by her sense of duty. We tried everything, but we never really saw more than glimpses of that Adora again... until you woke up in her arms.”

Melog settled down and rested their head in Catra's lap. She barely noticed.

“Adora needs you. And I think you need her too.”

At this point, Catra had two choices. Start crying, or get angry.

Get angry it was, then.

“You can't possibly get it, Sparkles,” she rasped. “You *can't.* If Adora... goes, then you'll still have Bow. And your father. And the rest of the princesses. I'll have nothing. No one.“

“Adora isn't going *anywhere.* And even if she did- hey. Look at me, Catra.”

Catra did.

“You'd still have me. You'd still have Bow, too. Not to mention Melog.” Glimmer gave Melog a pat, and like a traitor, they leaned into the touch. “We like you, and you're stuck with us. Got it?”

Catra wasn't sure how to tell Glimmer that she didn't think she'd be hanging around for very long if Adora died. Whether that meant stealing their spaceship and never seeing Etheria again or...

something else, she knew she couldn't bear to live here without Adora. She'd see Prime destroyed, make sure Melog would be alright without her, and then she'd go.

“Sure,” she managed, finally.

Evidently, she hadn't been very convincing. “You know, Catra, you aren't the only one scared you're going to lose people.”

“Yeah, yeah, you care about her too, I *know*-”

“I don't mean Adora,” interrupted Glimmer.

“...What?”

Now Glimmer was the one unable to maintain eye contact. “My father. It could already be too late. You know what dark magic can do to someone. My aunt is pretty sure he did what Shadow Weaver did. It's called the Spell of Obtainment. It's not something easy to reverse. Even if we save him, he could just... wither away. He'd rather die than survive like she had to. I know I would.”

“Oh.” What was Catra supposed to say? She was the reason that Micah's death would leave Glimmer an orphan instead of merely fatherless.

“I might be able to save him. *Might.* The theory is sound- I think, I'm not about to ask Shadow Weaver for more lessons- but if I'm going to pull it off I'll need to tap into the Moonstone as a raw energy source. Use it for spellcasting instead of for its natural powers. That's dark magic. But the inversion spell isn't. I don't know if it will work at all, and if it does, it could just kill him on the spot. Or me, if I screw up. But you know what, Catra?”

“What?”

“I'm going to try anyway. Because I fucking refuse to accept a future without my dad in it.”

And you shouldn't accept a future without Adora went unsaid, but Catra heard it.

She cares. Listen to her.

It was a while before Catra gathered the strength to speak.

"When?"

Glimmer didn't need to ask what she meant. "Shortly after midnight. Bow and I are going with Adora, everyone else is going to make as much trouble for Prime as they can while Entrapta breaks into a spire and takes out the chip network."

"She'll try to give you the slip."

"We won't let her."

"You better not."

"And *you* better be there for her."

Catra didn't acknowledge that. She got up. "Thanks for not dragging me back, Sparkles. I'll... I'll see you later. One way or another."

Letting Melog hide her from sight, Catra retreated into the forest. Glimmer made no move to follow.

Catra had lost the will to let her anger out on hapless clones. So she wandered aimlessly through the woods, an increasingly grumpy Melog cloaking her when necessary. True, Glimmer had no interest in making her return, but it was still best for her to refrain from using the Garnet's powers in case another, more practical princess- say, Netossa- sought to retrieve her for the final battle.

As tempting as it was to go out in a blaze of glory, a whip of lightning in each hand, that would be like asking Adora to swoop in and rescue her. That was the last thing she wanted.

There had to be some way she could convince Adora to stay. To try something else. Anything.

You're going to trust the First Ones? Again? How do we know they weren't just as bad as the jackasses who put the Heart there in the first place?

No. Adora trusted Mara. Even felt compelled to honor the sacrifice of a woman she'd never met. She-Ra solidarity or something. She would follow the last instruction left by Mara's squadron.

Can't we get Entrapta to look at the Failsafe? See if she can alter it so it won't. You know. Kill you?

No. As both she and Adora knew well, half of what Entrapta touched either became significantly deadlier or exploded. Or both, in that order. Adora wouldn't take the risk.

Etheria needs a She-Ra. Are you certain there will be another one after you, with all the First Ones gone?

Definitely not. Catra wasn't going to make Adora feel guilty for being unable to help people in the future because she'd already agreed to die to save them in the present. That would be nothing but cruel, and Catra liked to think she'd started to learn how to be some things other than cruel by now.

If you live I'll let you kiss me.

Her tail flicked in irritation. As if.

Catra picked up the alert from Melog in the same moment she, too, heard movement behind her. She turned, fading from view in the process.

All the tension left her when the perpetrator appeared: an old lady dressed in colorful rags. She had long, messy white hair, and a pair of glasses that made her eyes look just a bit too large. She smelled of burnt crust and dirt. Pretty much the opposite of what Catra would consider a threat, even if she was chipped.

Which, given as she was humming and poking around the undergrowth with the broom in her hands, Catra didn't think she was.

"Where are you? I know you're here, Broom said you were. Come out, then. No hiding from Madame Razz!"

So she was nuts. Also, alone in the Horde-infested woods. What would Adora do in this situation?

Right. The noble thing. Ugh.

"Hey. Old lady." Melog's illusion dropped, and the woman whipped around with surprising speed.

"Ah-HA! There you- oh, you aren't who I was looking for. Shoo, kitty. I'm busy."

Was Catra supposed to be insulted by *kitty?* She hadn't had the time or the nerve to ask Glimmer all that much about magicats. Not that it was important right now. She took a step forward. "Um. It's dangerous around here. Do you have somewhere safe to go? I'll, uh, walk you there."

She was terrible at this.

You are trying. That is enough.

"Ha! Danger? No, no. I remember being just fine tomorrow. Don't you worry, dearie."

"Don't I- lady, do you know what's going on? The invasion? Robots and clones everywhere? Come on, we need to get you out of the open."

Razz- that was probably her name- had completely lost interest in Catra, instead hunching down to get a closer look at Melog. “Oh! And hello to you! Tell me, have you seen a friend of mine? He looks a little bit like you.”

Melog meowed at her.

“Yes, yes. I see. Well, I suppose there's only one thing to do.” Razz nodded, very seriously.

What the fuck. Melog hadn't even *said* anything, just vocalized to be polite.

And then the crone had her by the arm, dragging her forward. Catra ripped herself away with a hiss. “Whoa, whoa. Hands off.”

“What? You were the one who wanted to escort me, yes? Make up your mind!”

Oh.

Flushing from embarrassment, Catra let herself be latched onto by a frail, bony hand and marched through the forest. As they walked, Razz carried on an animated, if one-sided, conversation with Melog. They were just as confused about this as Catra was.

Before long, they came to a clearing in the woods, in which stood a ramshackle cottage. Presumably Razz's home. Did she really live alone out here? Should Catra...

No. If Razz had managed out here by herself for this long, she'd be fine. It wasn't any of Catra's business.

Mercifully, the old lady let go of her arm. Catra rubbed it; Razz's grip had been weirdly strong.

“Okay, uh. We're here. You get inside, okay? Take a nap or something. Hopefully by tomorrow it'll be safe.” *Or it won't matter anymore.*

Razz peered at her, acknowledging Catra's presence for the first time in some minutes. “Thank you, dearie. But don't I know you?”

“...No? I should really go-”

“Hmm.” She squinted, blinked, and adjusted her glasses. “No, you're not She-Ra. Most of the time, anyway. You're Mara's friend, yes?”

What.

“No. I'm not. And Mara's dead.” *Melog? A little help?*

All she got was her own bewilderment echoing back at her all the stronger.

“Silly kitty, how can anyone die if they've lived? I see Mara all the time. And Adora. And you! Yes, that's it, you're Adora's friend! Pardon old Razz, she gets so mixed up sometimes. Tell me, how is Adora doing? It's so strange seeing one of you without the other.”

Oh. Good. Adora knew this lady and presumably wouldn't have left her here if she wasn't capable of taking care of herself. Then again, Razz also seemed to think she knew Catra, not to mention *Mara,* so her word wasn't exactly reliable.

“Right. Well, as long as you'll be fine-”

“I will! So will you. That's one thing I can't forget! You shouldn't either, Catra. Next time you come by, bring Adora too, won't you?”

The crazy old lady actually knew her name. Yeah, Catra was done with this. “...Sure,” she said, backing away.

“Good, good. Off with you then!”

Catra was already gone.

In the end, it was Melog that forced her hand. She'd been ignoring them for the past day, as much as she could without channeling the Garnet, and at some point they must have flat out gotten sick of her.

She'd expected them to leave her. Instead, they had pinned her down until she admitted exactly how she felt.

And then Prime began infecting Etheria. Her time was up. It was now or never.

Things were moving too fast for Catra to think twice. To be scared. To care that she was putting the Heart within Shadow Weaver's reach. None of that mattered compared to her returning to Adora's side.

"Drain me if you need to. Take the damn thing, for all I care. Just *get me there."*

And for once in her miserable life, Shadow Weaver listened. Something was different about her, Catra could tell. Her former guardian was almost... gentle.

It was creepy. Catra didn't trust it in the slightest. The last time Shadow Weaver had sounded like that, Catra had returned hours later to find her gone from her cell. She was planning something.

It was out of her hands now. Adora would have to manage on her own. Catra didn't expect to survive the next few minutes.

Whatever the hell this thing was, it barely flinched at Catra's lightning. She could stun it momentarily, but she was beginning to suspect that it wasn't that she was hurting it but that her powers messed with whatever mix of magic and technology controlled it. Not that there was really a difference, it just meant that it wouldn't back off no matter what she did. The Black Garnet offered, more than anything, the ability to inflict pain and inspire terror. Against an opponent that was incapable of pain and fear, and resistant to the effects of both electricity and magical disruption, there was little she could do.

Her claws tore gashes in its side, though not without all her strength going into each swipe; she couldn't keep that up indefinitely. Lightning burst apart its glowing eyes, shattering them into shards of glass, but it didn't seem to need eyes to locate her. All the better that she'd sent off Melog with Glimmer and Bow, then.

The stench of the poison seeping from the monster's tentacles made her gag even as she weaved around its strikes. Adora had been hit by that, green oozing from a wound in her side. Would she even survive to make it to the Heart?

No. She had to. And Catra would hold this thing off as long as Adora needed her to. And...

She would never see Adora again.

In a moment, her plans changed. If she was going to die, it would be at Adora's side.

She backed up against the wall of the chamber, baiting the creature forward and feigning a stumble. When it lunged, Catra slipped under the swipe of its pincers and leapt up onto its back.

Taking a deep breath, she plunged her claws as far into its metallic hide as they would go and unleashed everything she had left. The chamber glowed a fierce crimson. One by one, all her senses were overwhelmed. Her limbs trembled with the effort.

When her vision cleared, the beast lay immobile beneath her. How long it would stay down, she didn't know, but she had to take her chance. In one bound Catra made it to the exit.

Only for a nightmare to come to life.

“Ah, little sister.”

Her body turned to ice.

It had been one thing, hearing Prime's speech come from Micah's throat. And another, to see his larger-than-life form looming above Etheria. The first had allowed her to focus on a face other than Prime's, the second had been impersonal. Neither had been enough to dig up the pain she'd buried, the suffering she'd endured at his hands.

Catra couldn't move. She couldn't breath. She couldn't speak. For all intents and purposes, Prime had control of her once more.

"Perhaps you think I will hesitate to kill you, lest the Heart go dormant upon your death. Alas, you are no longer necessary, and neither is your Adora."

Rage thawed her out. Prime didn't deserve to speak Adora's name. Catra slashed through his hologram, intending to tear it apart with her power, but nothing happened. Not even a spark. She was too weak.

"You have truly fallen far. A pity. You had so much potential."

She heard the movement behind her, but she didn't react in time. Her leg was seized by a tendril, tearing through her skin and leaking acid into her veins. She felt it snuff out every trace of magic within her as she screamed in pain and fury and despair.

Catra couldn't sense the Garnet anymore. The warm place within her where the connection with Melog resided caught fire and turned to ash. She was alone.

Even now, Catra fought back, the venom sapping her strength with every second that passed. And still Prime carried on, insistent that his voice be the last one she heard.

"I have reigned since time immemorial. I am the light that pierces the shadows. I am the true peace of this universe. I am the harbinger of the new universe to come. I am Prime. Who did you think you were to defy me?"

Catra dug her claws into the floor, anchoring herself for the moment, and fixed her gaze, blurry with tears, on Prime. “I'm Princess Catra, you insufferable windbag,” she spat. “And when Adora kills you, you'll remember that you lost because of me. Because of us. Because of who we are and what we mean to each other, something you could never understand.”

Her declaration didn't have the effect she wanted. Not that she was really expecting it to. It had simply felt right. After all, she was going to die here. There was no point in denying who she was anymore.

“Very well, then, *Princess* Catra,” Prime sneered. “When the flesh is torn from your bones, may your last thought be of how pathetic you have made yourself, and how pointless it all was in the end. For Adora will join you soon. The Heart will be mine. You have failed.”

He raised a hand, and the creature dragged her upwards, towards those terrible teeth.

Catra kept her eyes on Prime. She'd die facing her nightmare.

Only for her nightmare to burst apart and be replaced by another. A far older one, masked and wreathed in darkness.

Shadow Weaver saved her.

Shadow Weaver sent her right into Adora's arms.

Shadow Weaver died as she watched.

And then it was Catra and Adora.

Adora didn't have She-Ra. Catra didn't have Melog or the Black Garnet. Neither of them had anyone else.

At the end of everything, it was just them. Just Catra, and just Adora. Like it was supposed to be.

They had each other. Whatever came next, that would have to be enough.

You're such an idiot.

I love you too.

Chapter End Notes

This chapter put up a hell of a fight. That probably shows. I mean, there's not exactly much breathing room in the last three episodes for me to avoid just retracing the steps of canon, which I insisted on keeping to a minimum throughout this fic. You know how the branching plots of Telltale games collapse into one at the end, rendering all previous choices irrelevant? That's what this was. Kind of the mindset behind this whole fic, really. The point wasn't to uproot canon or do anything exceptionally clever, just follow through with the consequences of a single different choice. Which, as stated, became harder and harder to limit myself to as we approached the end, thus resulting in several scenes that, save a couple of very slight differences, could easily be canon compliant.

Oh, and don't ask me what Razz's deal is. I don't know either.

All that's left is a short epilogue. I did my best to make it fun.

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra was going to fucking murder Hordak.

Not for the whole "trying to conquer Etheria" thing. Not for bearing responsibility for the hell in which she and Adora had been raised. Not for making a personal attempt on her life, either. She sort of had to forgive- or at least forget- all that, given what others had forgiven her for.

No, the problem was that he'd been at Prime's side when his "older brother" had last spoken to Catra. Which meant he'd heard what Catra had said. And he'd addressed her by the title she'd claimed when they met again, almost two weeks to the day Prime had fallen.

"Greetings, Princess Catra."

Adora had, impressively, managed to hold Catra back while laughing herself hoarse. Entrapta, who had also evidently borne witness to the worst mistake of her *life,* only made things worse by explaining, reciting Catra's words perfectly in the process. She insisted that Hordak had genuinely meant to be polite, bearing no ill will against Catra after everything, but Catra wasn't convinced.

She was also *never going to live it down.*

Whatever. Catra would decide on some way to get back at Hordak later. She had more important things to do.

"Are you sure?" asked Adora.

Catra gazed up at the Black Garnet. It had been so many different things to her, but now... it was just that. A thing. "Yeah."

"...And you're not just doing this so we won't call you a princess? Because I'm still going to call you a princess. *My* princess."

"I'm breaking up with you," Catra informed her.

The first time she'd made that joke, Adora had started crying. Not because she'd thought Catra was serious, she knew her better than that, but because it meant they were *together.* Glimmer had spent the next five minutes complaining about how sickening they were, as if she hadn't been both hanging off Bow's arm and blushing whenever Adora smiled for the past week.

Even now, Adora couldn't help but grin at those words. Catra had to look away so she wouldn't get distracted and forget why she was here.

She was here to right a wrong. To repay a debt. To, for the first time in her life, give up power willingly.

"Thanks for your help," she said to the Garnet, not caring that Adora was here to witness her talking to a rock. If anyone could understand, it would be Adora. She'd done way weirder princess stuff.

Shit, she'd just referred to herself as a princess again. She had to hurry.

Catra placed her hand on the Black Garnet. It didn't shock her. It couldn't hurt her anymore, even after this.

A ripple, spreading outward from where her claws rested on the surface. Then, another, and another in reverse, returning to where it had started. Warmth, bright and energizing, swept through her.

She closed her eyes.

The lightning within her vanished.

Catra opened her eyes, staring into the smoky depths of the runestone. She felt... different. Lighter and heavier at the same

time. She withdrew her hand and nodded one last time at the Black Garnet.

There were still so many shadows looming over her, and maybe there would always be a part of her that wished she could banish them with a mere thought. But no. That was the easy way, not the right way. Melog had shown her that much, and they would continue to whenever she needed reminding.

Besides, if she ever got lost in darkness, she had a beautiful glowing dork to guide her back to the light.

Catra turned to Adora and only pretended to resist matching her smile. “Let's go get Scorpia.”

“They're really going at it, huh.”

Predictably, Glimmer groaned and swatted her. “You could have phrased that differently.”

“I could have,” agreed Catra.

“...I don't get it.”

“I know, Adora.”

Chuckling, Bow peered into the distance. “Wait, did Scorpia just fly?”

“Yeah,” said Catra. “I have *no fucking idea* how she does that.”

Well, she did. Sort of. It had become abundantly clear within seconds of Scorpia first calling upon the lightning that her version of the Garnet's power was different from Catra's. Among the changes was that it was less precise, but with a far greater concussive impact, to the point that Scorpia could use it to throw herself forward. It was more propelled leaps than true flight, though that hardly mattered. Some of it could be attributed to the

release of the Heart- Catra had never cared to test her new limits before giving up the runestone, afraid that doing so would tempt her to keep it- but not all.

Catra's running theory was that if Scorpia knew how it worked, it wouldn't. In other words, wielders of runestones were limited first and foremost by their interpretations of their powers and their willingness to let their magic do what magic does best: break the rules.

She would under no circumstances be telling Glimmer this. She'd be creating a monster. Adora, perhaps, if they came up against some greater foe in the future and her idiot was somehow convinced that there was any force in the universe that could stand in her way. Glimmer had been right about that much.

Only that?

Alright, maybe Sparkles had been right about all of it.

Catra rested her head on Adora's shoulder, her hand on Melog's head, and watched the place they'd grown up be torn apart.

It had been Perfuma's idea. And in truth, the flower princess was doing most of the work. Nevertheless, if this was going to be Scorpia's kingdom, she should have a part in laying the foundation for it.

The resurrection of Stormhold was the cause that had convinced Scorpia to take up the mantle of the Black Garnet. She'd been surprisingly resistant to the idea.

First it was her insistence that Catra shouldn't have given it up, that Catra didn't owe her anything. That was blatantly untrue. Catra owed her, quite literally, a life and a limb. This was the best she could do.

Then Scorpia protested that it wouldn't accept her. This was firmly shut down by Perfuma and Catra, the former with a brief runestone history lesson and the latter with the argument that if

the Black Garnet had been willing to work with *her,* half-crazed as she'd been at the time, it clearly didn't have the highest of standards, and that even if it did, there could be no better person to trust with the power to cause pain and terror than the gentlest and kindest person on Etheria.

After Scorpia was done crying as a result of both that statement and Melog nuzzling her, she'd finally admitted that she didn't know how to be a “real” princess.

Perfuma had taken it from there. Catra was pretty sure they'd kissed after she took Perfuma's hint to leave. It had been a relief to let someone else handle it; Catra had requested Glimmer's help, initially, but Sparkles outright refused and almost started crying when Catra asked why. Some history there she didn't know, evidently.

They all had their wounds. Their shadows. Healing would be slow, but they had time.

And watching the Fright Zone crumble to pieces under the assault of two princesses was helping.

The initial plan had been for her and Adora to guide Bow and Glimmer up to their old hangout spot. They'd found it collapsed, either wrecked in some battle or by foliage when it overtook the already dilapidated metal structure. So instead the four of them had found a perch halfway up the nearest spire to watch the destruction.

Melog followed her as they always did. Not necessarily at her side, but they were never far. The bond between them and Catra had grown dramatically in the past two days; she suspected that the Garnet's magical disruption had been affecting them even when it wasn't active.

She'd been meaning to test whether she and Melog could weave illusions now. Like Melog had on Krytis; more than just invisibility. But that would require leaving Adora's side for long enough to do

some experimenting- after all, where was the fun if Adora saw the ensuing pranks coming- and Catra had not yet found the will to do so.

Her companion wasn't giving her answers. Their affinity for mischief, matching hers yet an inherent part of them, was one Catra had only fully recognized after the Garnet was gone. Similarly, despite being able to communicate far more complex ideas now, they hadn't told her what exactly they were.

She could feel the warm glow of amusement and contentment from them as they lay curled around her and Adora, their wispy tail in Glimmer's lap.

Hmm. Catra was pretty sure Entrapta was scrambling about somewhere inside the spire, robbing it of everything that still worked and many things that didn't. The faint cackling and occasional cooing were pretty big hints. Other than that, it was just her, Melog, her girlfriend, and her two best friends. It was nice.

Ew. She was getting mushy.

“So, Catra. Think you'll regret it? Giving up the Garnet?” Glimmer asked.

Catra shook her head automatically, then realized Adora, Bow, and Glimmer were all looking at her, expecting her to elaborate.

“I...” She hesitated, trying to find some other way to say it. She failed. “I think I’m okay with just being Catra.”

“Well,” Glimmer began, always looking for another opportunity to ruin her life, “another definition of ‘princess’ is ‘powerful magic user not bound to structured spellcasting’ so technically-”

“Finish that sentence, Sparkles, and I’m not letting you flirt with my girlfriend anymore.”

Adora started to make the happy little hum she made whenever Catra referred to her as her girlfriend, then cut off as she processed what Catra had actually said. “Wait, what?”

Glimmer flushed. “I'm *not*-”

“Sure.” Catra decided to be merciful. This time. “Besides, by that logic, I'm pretty sure Melog's the princess.” She addressed them. “How's that sound?”

Melog looked at her, yawned, then settled down for a nap.

“They're thrilled.”

Apparently forgetting that she was supposed to be fuming at Catra, Glimmer laughed.

“That's okay, Catra. You can join me in the non-princess club,” offered Bow. “It's been so lonely all these years.”

“Nope. She's still a princess.” Adora stuck her tongue out at Bow. “I'm She-Ra, and I say so.”

“That's not how that works-”

Catra let Glimmer's protests and Adora's laughter fade into the background. A purr rose in her chest as she curled up to her girlfriend's side, closing her eyes.

There was a lot of work to do yet. But for now, Catra could rest.

Chapter End Notes

> Surprise, y'all get the epilogue a day earlier than planned. I realized that formatting and posting this tomorrow would cut into time spent with my girlfriend, and like. Fuck that concept in its entirety.
>
> Adora *absolutely* knows common euphemisms after hanging around Glimmer for three years. She's just trolling Catra. It

will take Catra approximately two more months to realize this.

Anyway. Thanks for reading. I have one other, wildly different She-Ra fic mostly planned and partially written, though still far from completion, and quite a number of small ideas that I'm trying to figure out how best to write. (They're mostly just poly fluff and worldbuilding.) It might be a while before I return, but I'm not done with these idiots yet.

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